

ENGLISH FOR PUBLIC SERVICE PROFESSIONALS

Government and Public Administration English

Explain the process clearly. Make public decisions understandable.

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Eight lessons. Eleven extended conversations.

INSIDE THE BOOK

192 vocabulary entries / 128 reusable phrases
220 extended-dialogue turns / 11 transfer exchanges
Word banks and explained answer keys

Upper-intermediate to advanced (B2-C1). For program officers, public-service staff, procurement teams, grant administrators, records staff, and interagency coordinators.

2026 edition

Eight scenarios. Eight skills.

Eight public-service conversations: distinguish a proposal from current guidance, manage a public meeting, explain a procurement evaluation, reconcile a grant report, assign an interagency handoff, repair a resident referral, review a records response, and connect spending to measurable outcomes.

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Clear service without unsupported promises

Public administration combines procedural accuracy with accessible explanations. These conversations practice explaining what a document means, what an office can do, who owns the next step, and what the evidence actually establishes.

Name the document and its status

A proposal, current guidance, application receipt, and formal decision do different jobs. Identify the relevant version and status before explaining its consequence.

"That document is a proposal; the current application guidance has not changed."

Explain the boundary and the route forward

A resident needs more than a statement that an issue belongs elsewhere. Name the responsible office, explain the referral, and confirm how the handoff will be tracked.

"The permit team decides that issue; I will confirm that it has received your referral."

Keep judgments traceable to evidence

A procurement conclusion, grant total, or performance claim should point to a defined criterion and supporting record. A confident label does not replace the reasoning.

"Which published criterion does that strength address?"

Respect participation and privacy together

Fair access to a process does not mean publishing every personal detail. Use the announced participation arrangements and the applicable information-handling rules.

"We can record the issue without reading your personal details into the meeting record."

PROFESSIONAL BOUNDARIES

All programs, residents, offices, applications, figures, meetings, and local procedures are fictional. This is professional-English instruction, not legal advice or authority to decide eligibility, award contracts, release records, or spend funds. U.S. federal references support selected terminology; their rules do not automatically govern every local, state, tribal, or international office.

The proposal has not changed the current application test

A Read the situation

Explain document status and a current requirement without confusing a preliminary check with a formal eligibility decision.

The fictional Brookfield Training Grant currently requires 12 months of residence, plus other conditions. Published guidance G4 explains the current requirements. A separate proposal P2 would reduce the residence period to six months, but it has not been adopted and has no effective date. Resident Amina has lived in the area for nine months and brings P2 to the service desk. Program officer Theo must identify the current residence requirement, explain the proposal accurately, and avoid either promising an award or treating this conversation as a formal denial of an application.

PEOPLE / Amina: Resident | Theo: Program information officer

CORRECT THE DOCUMENT, NOT THE PERSON

A resident may reasonably assume that a published document describes the current service. Acknowledge why the documents look confusing, then show their status and identifiers. Explain the current process without implying that asking a question is itself an application or a final decision.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which document explains the current requirements?

- A A future decision not yet issued
- C Guidance G4

- B A resident's summary of P2
- D Proposal P2

2. What does P2 propose?

- A Removing all other conditions
- C Reducing it to nine months immediately

- B Reducing the residence period to six months
- D Awarding every submitted application

3. What can Theo accurately say about nine months?

- A It satisfies the current residence condition.
- C It guarantees eligibility once P2 is discussed.

- B It establishes a complete formal eligibility decision.
- D It is below the current 12-month residence condition.

[Answers and explanations: page 85.](#)

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

program rule

A requirement governing a defined public program.

IN USE explain the program rules

eligibility criterion

A condition used to decide whether an applicant qualifies.

IN USE verify an eligibility criterion

current guidance

Published explanatory material reflecting the presently applicable position.

IN USE consult current guidance

proposal

A suggested change that has not necessarily been adopted.

IN USE distinguish the proposal

draft guidance

Preliminary explanatory material not yet issued as the final version.

IN USE identify draft guidance

adoption

Formal acceptance of a proposed measure through the applicable process.

IN USE confirm adoption

effective date

The date a measure begins to apply under its terms.

IN USE check the effective date

implementation date

The planned or required start of operational delivery.

IN USE confirm the implementation date

transition provision

A rule addressing movement from an old arrangement to a new one.

IN USE check transition provisions

residence requirement

A condition concerning where or how long a person has lived.

IN USE explain the residence requirement

application intake

Receipt and initial handling of an application.

IN USE arrange application intake

completeness check

A check that required application information is present.

IN USE perform a completeness check

Precision check

A proposal may be public without being in effect. A publication date does not necessarily establish adoption or applicability. Here G4 describes the current condition, while P2 remains an unadopted proposal with no effective date.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

eligibility determination

An authorized decision about qualification under the applicable criteria.

IN USE issue an eligibility determination

supporting evidence

Documents or information used to substantiate a claim.

IN USE identify supporting evidence

verification

Checking information against appropriate evidence.

IN USE complete verification

exception

A defined departure from a general requirement where permitted.

IN USE check an authorized exception

discretion

Authorized judgment within the limits of a rule or role.

IN USE exercise defined discretion

statutory authority

Power granted by legislation.

IN USE identify statutory authority

rulemaking

The process of developing and issuing regulations.

IN USE follow the rulemaking process

public comment

Input submitted through an announced public consultation process.

IN USE submit public comment

comment deadline

The closing time for input under a specified process.

IN USE verify the comment deadline

notice

An official communication about a process, action, or decision.

IN USE read the notice

superseded version

A document version replaced by a later applicable version.

IN USE identify a superseded version

case-specific advice

Guidance tailored to a person's facts within the provider's authority.

IN USE seek case-specific advice

Precision check

A residence condition is one part of eligibility, not the whole decision. Explaining that nine months is below twelve does not itself issue a formal denial. Use the actual intake and decision processes, and do not invent an exception or future entitlement.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE CONFUSION

"I can see why these two documents are easy to confuse."

NAME THE PROPOSAL

"P2 is a proposed change, not an adopted rule."

STATE THE PROPOSED CHANGE

"The proposal would reduce that period to six months."

APPLY THE STATED COMPARISON

"Nine months is below the current residence requirement."

IDENTIFY THE CURRENT SOURCE

"G4 explains the requirements that currently apply."

STATE THE CURRENT CONDITION

"The current residence requirement is twelve months."

QUALIFY THE FUTURE

"No effective date has been established for P2."

KEEP THE DECISION BOUNDARY

"This explanation is not a formal eligibility determination."

Currently apply

Identifies the present position rather than a possible future one.

Would reduce

Describes the effect of a proposal without claiming adoption.

No effective date

Prevents readers from inventing when a change begins.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

AVOID A GUARANTEE

"I cannot promise an award based on the proposal."

ASK ABOUT THE SOURCE

"Which document and version are you reading?"

CHECK FOR AUTHORITY

"We should not invent an exception that the rules do not provide."

POINT TO THE NOTICE

"The official notice explains how to submit comments."

PRESERVE OTHER CRITERIA

"The program also has other conditions to assess."

EXPLAIN THE PROCESS

"I can show you the current application and review steps."

SEPARATE PARTICIPATION

"A comment on the proposal is not a grant application."

CLOSE WITH A CLEAR DISTINCTION

"Use G4 for the current requirements and P2 for the proposed change."

Not a formal

Preserves the boundary between information and an authorized decision.

Also has

Prevents one criterion from being mistaken for the entire test.

A comment ... not an application

Distinguishes two public processes with different purposes.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which explanation is accurate?

- A** P2 has already removed the other criteria.
- B** P2 proposes six months; G4 still describes the current twelve-month condition.
- C** P2's publication immediately replaced G4.
- D** Nine months qualifies because it lies between six and twelve.

2. Which response avoids an unauthorized decision?

- A** Nine months is below the current condition; I can explain the formal review process.
- B** This conversation is your final denial notice.
- C** I approve the award under the future rule.
- D** I will create an exception because the proposal seems likely.

3. What should Theo check before describing a change as operative?

- A** Its adoption, applicable terms, and effective date
- B** Its publication date and consultation deadline only
- C** Whether the application website links to the proposal
- D** Whether the proposal has completed its comment period

4. Which statement keeps the processes distinct?

- A** Asking about G4 waives the right to apply.
- B** Application intake guarantees an award.
- C** Commenting on P2 does not itself submit an application for the grant.
- D** Every comment automatically becomes an application.

Answers and explanations: [page 85](#).

The proposal has not changed the current application test

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

public comment / application intake / eligibility determination / residence requirement / proposal / effective date / transition provision / adoption / eligibility criterion / current guidance

- 01 **Amina:** This came from your grant page. It says six months of residence, and I have been here nine. Have I been using the wrong application guidance?
- 02 **Theo:** Let us check the ¹ _____ you are holding. This is P2, which suggests a change. G4 is the guidance describing the requirements that currently apply.
- 03 **Amina:** Both files look official. I took the shorter period to mean the rules had changed. Nothing on this printout explains the difference to me.
- 04 **Theo:** I understand the confusion. The ² _____ still describes a twelve-month residence requirement. P2 would reduce that to six months, but the proposal has not been adopted.
- 05 **Amina:** Does the date at the top of P2 mean the shorter period started then?
- 06 **Theo:** That is the publication date, not an ³ _____. No effective date has been established for this proposal. We should not tell applicants that the six-month condition already applies.
- 07 **Amina:** So my nine months does not meet the condition you are using at the moment?
- 08 **Theo:** It is below the current ⁴ _____ of twelve months. That explains this particular condition, but it is not a formal decision on an application or a complete assessment of your circumstances.
- 09 **Amina:** I do not want a question at the desk to be recorded as a final rejection. I am trying to understand the process.
- 10 **Theo:** This is not an ⁵ _____. I can show you the actual application and review steps, including where to obtain case-specific information within the program's process.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 10.

- 11 **Amina:** Are there other conditions beyond residence? The proposal headline makes the program sound much simpler.
- 12 **Theo:** Yes. Residence is one ⁶ _____, not the entire test. The current guidance lists the other requirements, and an award should not be promised from one headline.
- 13 **Amina:** If the proposal is adopted later, should I assume it will apply to every application already on file?
- 14 **Theo:** We would need to read any ⁷ _____ in the adopted measure. We cannot invent how pending applications would be handled before the actual terms and dates are available.
- 15 **Amina:** I would like to support the change. Is submitting a comment the same as asking to receive the grant?
- 16 **Theo:** No. A ⁸ _____ concerns the proposal. It does not itself submit a grant application. The official notice explains the comment route and the deadline for that process.
- 17 **Amina:** Then I should keep the two documents separate and not rely on the proposed six-month period for the current requirements.
- 18 **Theo:** Exactly. Check the ⁹ _____ status before treating a change as operative. Until then, use G4 for the current program explanation and P2 for the suggested change.
- 19 **Amina:** Thank you. Please show me where the current application steps are, and I will read the proposal notice separately.
- 20 **Theo:** I will. The ¹⁰ _____ information will explain what to submit and how the review proceeds. Today's explanation neither guarantees an award nor substitutes for that formal process.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 86

1. proposal | 2. current guidance | 3. effective date | 4. residence requirement | 5. eligibility determination | 6. eligibility criterion | 7. transition provision | 8. public comment | 9. adoption | 10. application intake

Distinguish another current condition

F Say it

Guidance H3 states an eight-month residence condition. Proposal Q1 would reduce it to four months but is not adopted. Resident Jo has six months of residence. No formal application decision has been made.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

H3 / not been made / eight months / not adopted

Officer: "The current guidance is ¹ _____."

Resident: "The current residence condition is ² _____."

Officer: "The proposal's status is ³ _____."

Resident: "A formal application decision has ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 86

1. H3 | 2. eight months | 3. not adopted | 4. not been made

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8 in pairs, stressing proposal, current, and publication date.
2. Swap roles for turns 9-20, keeping an eligibility explanation separate from a formal decision.
3. Complete the H3 exchange below and check every answer before reading it aloud.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Give the next speaker a fair turn

A Read the situation

Apply an announced participation process consistently while acknowledging disagreement and preserving the public record.

A fictional town consultation has announced three minutes per speaker, one initial turn each before second turns, and written submissions accepted until Friday at 17:00 local time. Two speakers have already used their initial turns and ask to speak again while five registered speakers remain unheard. Facilitator Rosa and meeting clerk Ian must continue the queue consistently, regardless of whether a speaker supports or opposes the proposal. The meeting gathers input; it is not an up-or-down public vote. Any accessibility request should be handled through the stated meeting arrangements rather than dismissed as an attempt to gain extra influence.

PEOPLE / Rosa: Meeting facilitator | Ian: Meeting clerk

BE FIRM ABOUT PROCESS AND NEUTRAL ABOUT VIEWPOINT

A public disagreement may be strongly expressed without justifying unequal access to the microphone. Refer to the announced turn-taking process, acknowledge the contribution, and explain the next opportunity. Keep procedural decisions separate from agreement with the speaker.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Who should be called next under the announced process?

- | | |
|--|---|
| A Only a speaker supporting the proposal | B Whoever speaks most loudly |
| C The next registered speaker who has not had an initial turn | D Either repeat speaker before the waiting group |

2. What is the written-submission deadline?

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|---|
| A Friday at 17:00 local time | B Immediately after each speaker's turn |
| C Monday at 09:00 | D An unannounced time chosen after the meeting |

3. What is this meeting's purpose?

- | | |
|--|---|
| A To count applause as a binding ballot | B To approve every speaker's request |
| C To gather input, not decide the proposal by a public vote | D To award a contract immediately |

Answers and explanations: [page 87](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

consultation

A process of seeking input before or during decision development.

IN USE conduct a consultation

stakeholder

A person or group affected by or interested in an issue.

IN USE hear from stakeholders

facilitator

A person guiding a discussion and its agreed process.

IN USE support the facilitator

meeting clerk

The person maintaining meeting records and administrative arrangements.

IN USE brief the meeting clerk

agenda

The planned sequence of meeting business.

IN USE follow the agenda

speaker queue

The ordered list of people waiting to speak.

IN USE manage the speaker queue

speaking allocation

The time or opportunity assigned to a speaker.

IN USE explain the speaking allocation

initial turn

A person's first opportunity to speak in the relevant round.

IN USE complete initial turns

second turn

A later speaking opportunity after an initial contribution.

IN USE allow second turns

time limit

The stated maximum duration of an activity or contribution.

IN USE apply the time limit

procedural reminder

A statement recalling the process currently being followed.

IN USE give a procedural reminder

viewpoint neutrality

Consistent treatment without favoring a position on the issue.

IN USE maintain viewpoint neutrality

Precision check

A consultation can collect evidence, experiences, and arguments without being a referendum. Do not describe applause, speaker counts, or the most forceful contribution as a binding vote when the announced process gives decision authority elsewhere.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

oral submission

Input delivered by speaking.

IN USE record an oral submission

written submission

Input provided in written form.

IN USE accept written submissions

submission deadline

The final time for receiving input under the process.

IN USE state the submission deadline

meeting record

Documentation of the meeting and its relevant proceedings.

IN USE maintain the meeting record

attribution

Identification of the source of a statement.

IN USE check attribution

summary

A condensed account preserving the relevant meaning.

IN USE verify the summary

clarification

An explanation resolving ambiguity in a statement or process.

IN USE request clarification

accessibility arrangement

A measure supporting participation by people with access needs.

IN USE coordinate accessibility arrangements

interpretation

Spoken or signed language conversion supporting understanding.

IN USE arrange interpretation

accommodation request

A request for an adjustment to support access or participation.

IN USE handle an accommodation request

deliberation

Structured examination of issues before a decision.

IN USE distinguish input from deliberation

decision authority

The person or body empowered to make the relevant decision.

IN USE identify the decision authority

Precision check

Consistent turn-taking does not mean ignoring accessibility arrangements. Handle access requests through the stated process, and explain any authorized adjustment without judging the speaker's viewpoint. Acknowledge a contribution without implying endorsement of its substance.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE CONTRIBUTION

"Thank you; your concern has been recorded."

NAME THE WAITING GROUP

"Five registered speakers have not yet been heard."

APPLY THE TIME LIMIT

"The speaking allocation is three minutes."

AVOID A PERSONAL REBUKE

"I am applying the turn-taking process, not judging your position."

RECALL THE PROCESS

"We announced one initial turn each before second turns."

MOVE THE QUEUE

"I will now call the next person awaiting an initial turn."

SEPARATE VIEWPOINT

"The same process applies to support and opposition."

OFFER THE STATED ROUTE

"Written submissions remain open until Friday at 17:00 local time."

Has been recorded

Acknowledges receipt without endorsing the claim.

Before second turns

States the priority rule that controls the next action.

Same process

Makes consistent treatment explicit.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

CLARIFY THE MEETING PURPOSE

"This consultation gathers input; it is not a public ballot."

PRESERVE ATTRIBUTION

"Please identify that as the speaker's claim, not a verified finding."

AVOID AN INVENTED PROMISE

"I cannot guarantee a second turn before the remaining initial speakers."

CLOSE THE ORAL SESSION

"The meeting record will preserve the contributions received."

CHECK THE RECORD

"Does that summary accurately capture the point you made?"

HANDLE ACCESS NEEDS

"Let us use the announced accessibility arrangements for that request."

EXPLAIN DECISION AUTHORITY

"The designated body will make the decision through its stated process."

RESTATE THE NEXT STEP

"We will explain how the input proceeds to the decision stage."

Not judging your position

Separates procedure from agreement or disagreement.

Accurately capture

Checks the meaning of a summary with its source.

Speaker's claim

Preserves attribution instead of presenting an allegation as an official finding.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which intervention best follows the process?

- A** Thank you; we will hear the remaining initial speakers before returning to second turns.
- B** We will let supporters speak twice before opponents speak once.
- C** The loudest speaker can choose the queue.
- D** All remaining speakers lose their turns because time is tight.

2. Which record entry is appropriately attributed?

- A** Every concern is an official finding.
- B** A speaker reported concerns about evening access.
- C** Evening access is proven inadequate because one speaker said so.
- D** The entire community unanimously opposes the proposal.

3. How should an access request be handled?

- A** By counting the request as the person's initial contribution
- B** By postponing all access arrangements until written consultation
- C** Through the announced accessibility arrangements
- D** By applying an identical format without checking an adjustment

4. Which explanation correctly describes the meeting?

- A** Applause determines the binding result.
- B** The two longest speakers decide the outcome.
- C** Every written submission guarantees adoption of its request.
- D** It gathers input for the designated decision process.

Answers and explanations: page 87.

Give the next speaker a fair turn

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

accessibility arrangement / meeting record / consultation / viewpoint neutrality / attribution / procedural reminder / initial turn / submission deadline / decision authority / second turn

- 01 **Rosa:** Before I reopen the floor, can you check the queue? The two people asking to come back have both spoken, and I can see others still waiting.
- 02 **Ian:** Five people are waiting for an ¹ _____. The two asking to return have already used theirs. We announced that everyone gets that first opportunity before we move to second turns.
- 03 **Rosa:** I heard their concerns. Now I need to move the meeting on without making it sound as though disagreement costs someone a turn.
- 04 **Ian:** Use a ² _____. Thank them, confirm that their points were recorded, and explain that the next registered person who has not spoken will now be called.
- 05 **Rosa:** One supports the proposal and the other opposes it. We need to make clear that this is not about either position.
- 06 **Ian:** That is ³ _____. Apply the same initial-turn rule and the same announced three-minute allocation. The explanation should focus on process, not agreement with their arguments.
- 07 **Rosa:** Could we promise them another opportunity at the end, so they are less frustrated now?
- 08 **Ian:** We can explain the possibility of a ⁴ _____, but not guarantee it before the remaining initial speakers. We also have the written-submission route that was announced at the start.
- 09 **Rosa:** Please remind me of the exact deadline. I do not want to give two different times in the same meeting.
- 10 **Ian:** The ⁵ _____ is Friday at 17:00 local time. We should repeat the same time and submission instructions so that people can use that route reliably.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 19.

- 11 **Rosa:** One resident asked whether the amount of applause will determine the result. We should correct that before the next speaker.
- 12 **Ian:** Yes. This ⁶ _____ gathers input. It is not an up-or-down vote, and applause does not replace the designated decision process or establish what everyone in the town thinks.
- 13 **Rosa:** The clerk's summary says that residents cannot reach the site in the evening. Only one person has made that claim so far.
- 14 **Ian:** Keep the ⁷ _____. Record that a speaker reported an evening-access concern. We can preserve the point without turning it into a verified finding about every resident.
- 15 **Rosa:** Another participant has asked for an adjustment so they can follow and contribute to the discussion. How should I respond?
- 16 **Ian:** Use the announced ⁸ _____ process. Do not treat the request as an attempt to gain influence. Check the appropriate adjustment and communicate it clearly without disclosing unnecessary personal details.
- 17 **Rosa:** I will call the next initial speaker, restate the allocation, and explain that the written route remains available.
- 18 **Ian:** I will update the ⁹ _____ and check that summaries retain their meaning. Recording a concern does not mean the office endorses it, but it should not be lost.
- 19 **Rosa:** Before closing, we also need to say who makes the decision and where people can find the next-stage information.
- 20 **Ian:** Agreed. Name the ¹⁰ _____ and the stated next steps. That gives participants a useful account of how their input moves forward without promising that every requested change will be adopted.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 88

1. initial turn | 2. procedural reminder | 3. viewpoint neutrality | 4. second turn | 5. submission deadline | 6. consultation | 7. attribution | 8. accessibility arrangement | 9. meeting record | 10. decision authority

Apply another meeting process

F Say it

A meeting allows two minutes per initial speaker before repeat turns. Three registered people remain unheard. Written input closes Wednesday at 12:00 local time. The session is consultation, not a ballot.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

Wednesday at 12:00 local time / three / two minutes / consultation

Chair: "The initial speaking allocation is ¹ _____."

Clerk: "The number of registered people still unheard is ² _____."

Chair: "Written input closes ³ _____."

Clerk: "The session is a ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 88

1. two minutes | 2. three | 3. Wednesday at 12:00 local time | 4. consultation

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10 with a calm, firm procedural reminder.
2. Swap roles for turns 11-20; stress the difference between a reported concern and an official finding.
3. Complete the second meeting exchange and read back its allocation, queue, deadline, and purpose.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Best value needs a reason, not just a label

A Read the situation

Connect a procurement recommendation to published criteria, comparable evidence, and an authorized decision process.

A fictional office evaluates two service proposals using published maximum scores: technical approach 50, service delivery 30, and price 20. Recorded weighted scores are A: 45, 25, 16, total 86; B: 40, 24, 18, total 82. A costs \$120,000 and B costs \$110,000. The method permits a documented trade-off, but the draft note only says A is best value. Evaluator Dev and procurement officer Marta must explain the scored differences and the \$10,000 premium. A vendor's local address is not a published criterion. The award has not been authorized.

PEOPLE / Dev: Technical evaluator | Marta: Procurement officer

CHALLENGE THE RATIONALE WITHOUT REOPENING THE RULES

A request to explain an evaluation is not necessarily an accusation of bias. Link the judgment to the announced criteria and the submitted evidence. Do not quietly introduce a new preference after seeing which supplier it would favor.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What are the recorded totals?

- A A has 86 and B has 82.
- C Both have 90.

- B A has 82 and B has 86.
- D A has 45 and B has 40 overall.

2. What is A's price premium?

- A \$30,000
- C \$4,000

- B \$10,000
- D \$16,000

3. Which consideration is not a published criterion?

- A The vendor's local address
- C Service delivery

- B Technical approach
- D Price

Answers and explanations: [page 89](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

procurement

The process of obtaining goods or services under applicable rules.

IN USE manage procurement

solicitation

A formal request inviting offers under stated requirements.

IN USE review the solicitation

offeror

A supplier submitting an offer in response to a solicitation.

IN USE evaluate the offeror

evaluation factor

A stated dimension used to assess proposals.

IN USE apply the evaluation factors

subfactor

A defined component of a broader evaluation factor.

IN USE assess the subfactor

relative importance

The stated relationship in significance among evaluation factors.

IN USE state relative importance

weighted score

A score already adjusted to reflect the specified scoring importance.

IN USE verify the weighted scores

scoring matrix

A structured record of scores against criteria.

IN USE reconcile the scoring matrix

technical approach

The proposed method for delivering the required work.

IN USE evaluate the technical approach

service-delivery plan

The proposed arrangement for providing the required service.

IN USE assess the service-delivery plan

price premium

The amount by which one price exceeds another.

IN USE justify the price premium

best value

The most advantageous result under the applicable selection method.

IN USE explain the best-value judgment

Precision check

The scores are already weighted. Do not apply the 50/30/20 maxima a second time. The totals are 86 and 82. A higher score is relevant under this method, but the permitted trade-off still needs a reasoned record of the benefits and premium.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

03

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

trade-off

A comparison accepting one disadvantage for a supported benefit.

IN USE document the trade-off

strength

An assessed favorable feature under an evaluation criterion.

IN USE substantiate a strength

weakness

An assessed unfavorable feature under an evaluation criterion.

IN USE document a weakness

deficiency

A material failure to meet a stated requirement under the applicable method.

IN USE identify a deficiency

past performance

Evidence of how a supplier performed on relevant previous work.

IN USE assess past performance

evaluation narrative

Written reasoning supporting the recorded assessment.

IN USE complete the evaluation narrative

source selection

The process of choosing a supplier under the applicable procedure.

IN USE support source selection

award authority

The person or body empowered to authorize the contract award.

IN USE confirm award authority

conflict of interest

An interest that may improperly influence, or appear to influence, official judgment.

IN USE disclose a conflict of interest

recusal

Withdrawal from a matter under the applicable conflict-handling process.

IN USE arrange recusal

audit trail

Records allowing a decision or transaction to be traced.

IN USE preserve the audit trail

debriefing

A structured explanation of a procurement outcome under applicable procedures.

IN USE prepare a debriefing

Precision check

Best value is a conclusion under a specified selection method, not a synonym for lowest price or local supplier. Link each claimed strength to a published factor and proposal evidence. An evaluation recommendation is not the same as an authorized award.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

03

ASK FOR THE RATIONALE

"What does best value mean under this selection method?"

CHECK THE ARITHMETIC

"The weighted scores total eighty-six for A and eighty-two for B."

NAME THE PRICE DIFFERENCE

"A carries a ten-thousand-dollar premium."

LINK EVIDENCE TO JUDGMENT

"Cite the proposal evidence beside the relevant criterion."

RETURN TO THE CRITERIA

"Let us use the published evaluation factors."

AVOID DOUBLE WEIGHTING

"These scores have already been weighted."

IDENTIFY THE STRENGTH

"Which submitted feature supports the technical advantage?"

EXPLAIN THE TRADE-OFF

"The note must explain why the assessed benefit justifies the premium."

Under this method

Limits the conclusion to the actual procurement procedure.

Already weighted

Prevents a second adjustment that would distort the scores.

Supports the advantage

Requests evidence for a comparative judgment.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

03

REJECT AN ADDED PREFERENCE

"Local address is not a published criterion."

CLARIFY THE STATUS

"This is an evaluation recommendation, not an award."

HANDLE A CONFLICT

"Any relevant interest should go through the conflict-review process."

KEEP THE RECORD REVIEWABLE

"A reader should be able to trace each conclusion to its evidence."

PRESERVE EQUAL TREATMENT

"Apply the same evidence standard to both offers."

CHECK AUTHORITY

"The designated award authority still needs to decide."

AVOID SCORE-ONLY REASONING

"The total does not replace the evaluation narrative."

CLOSE THE REVISION

"Revise the rationale without changing the published method."

Justifies the premium

Connects a benefit to the additional cost rather than ignoring price.

Not a published criterion

Identifies an impermissible addition under the stated process.

Recommendation, not an award

Separates the evaluation team's work from final authorization.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which evaluation note is strongest?

- A** Add local address as a deciding factor after scoring.
- B** Ignore price because A has the higher total.
- C** Link A's scored strengths to proposal evidence and explain the \$10,000 premium.
- D** State best value without further detail.

2. What should happen to the existing weighted scores?

- A** Multiply each one by its factor maximum again.
- B** Replace the price scores with the dollar figures.
- C** Average only the two highest factors.
- D** Check their arithmetic without applying the weights again.

3. Which statement preserves authority?

- A** The evaluation recommends A; the award decision remains pending.
- B** The evaluator's preference alone executes the contract.
- C** A's local address automatically authorizes the award.
- D** A four-point lead removes every approval requirement.

4. Which challenge is appropriate?

- A** Can we replace the method with a personal impression?
- B** Which published factor and submitted evidence support that claimed strength?
- C** Can we add a factor that favors the supplier we prefer?
- D** Should we remove B's stronger price score?

Answers and explanations: [page 89](#).

Best value needs a reason, not just a label

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

award authority / scoring matrix / conflict of interest / price premium / evaluation factor / evaluation narrative / Best value / audit trail / trade-off / weighted score

- 01 **Marta:** I can check the totals, but I cannot sign this rationale yet. Best value is doing a lot of work in the draft. Show me what sits behind it.
- 02 **Dev:** The ¹ _____ gives A forty-five for technical approach, twenty-five for service delivery, and sixteen for price. B has forty, twenty-four, and eighteen respectively.
- 03 **Marta:** That gives eighty-six and eighty-two. Are those raw marks that still need the fifty, thirty, and twenty weighting applied?
- 04 **Dev:** No, each ² _____ is final for that factor. We should check the addition, but applying the weights again would change the evaluation rather than verify it.
- 05 **Marta:** A is also ten thousand dollars more expensive. The note cannot simply report the higher total and leave that difference unexplained.
- 06 **Dev:** Agreed. The ³ _____ is part of the decision. A costs one hundred twenty thousand, while B costs one hundred ten thousand. Our method permits a documented trade-off.
- 07 **Marta:** Which features support the technical difference? A reader should not have to infer a benefit from the score alone.
- 08 **Dev:** I need to expand the ⁴ _____. Each assessed strength should point to the submitted material and the technical factor it addresses, rather than a general impression that A seems better.
- 09 **Marta:** Someone suggested mentioning that A's office is local. Does the solicitation give us a factor for that?
- 10 **Dev:** No. It is not an ⁵ _____, so we should not add it now. The published dimensions are technical approach, service delivery, and price, with the stated relative importance.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

03

Continue with the word bank on page 28.

- 11 **Marta:** We also need to show that B's stronger price result was recognized, not quietly removed because the team prefers A.
- 12 **Dev:** The ⁶ _____ explanation should do that. It must explain why the evidenced benefits of A are judged worth the premium, if that remains the supported recommendation.
- 13 **Marta:** Is a four-point lead sufficient by itself? The summary says highest score therefore award, which skips the trade-off we have just discussed.
- 14 **Dev:** No. ⁷ _____ depends on this selection method and a defensible record. We should not present our scoring example as a rule for every procurement.
- 15 **Marta:** Before circulation, check that any interests affecting an evaluator have gone through the proper disclosure process.
- 16 **Dev:** I will confirm the ⁸ _____ review status. That belongs in the appropriate record, without turning an unsupported suspicion about a colleague into an allegation in the evaluation note.
- 17 **Marta:** Once the explanation is complete, who actually authorizes the contract award? The draft sounds as though the evaluation team already has.
- 18 **Dev:** The designated ⁹ _____ still needs to decide. I will label the document as our recommendation and remove wording that suggests an award has already been made.
- 19 **Marta:** Good. Keep the published criteria, the verified totals, the evidence, and the premium visible in the revised note.
- 20 **Dev:** I will preserve that ¹⁰ _____. The revision will explain the recommendation under the existing method, not introduce a new preference to make the result easier to defend.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 90

1. scoring matrix | 2. weighted score | 3. price premium | 4. evaluation narrative | 5. evaluation factor | 6. trade-off | 7. Best value | 8. conflict of interest | 9. award authority | 10. audit trail

Explain another scored comparison

F Say it

03

Under a stated trade-off method, C has already-weighted scores of 42, 26, and 17. D has 40, 25, and 19. C costs \$75,000 and D \$70,000. Award approval is pending.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

\$5,000 / 84 / approval pending / 85

Evaluator: "C's total weighted score is ¹ _____."

Officer: "D's total weighted score is ² _____."

Evaluator: "C's price premium is ³ _____."

Officer: "The award status is ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 90

1. 85 | 2. 84 | 3. \$5,000 | 4. approval pending

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8, saying each factor score and total clearly.
2. Swap roles for turns 9-20, stressing published factors and recommendation rather than award.
3. Complete the C-and-D comparison; verify the totals and premium before reading the result aloud.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The total matches the spreadsheet, not the evidence

04

A Read the situation

Reconcile expenditure categories to supporting records and explain an unresolved difference without inventing a balancing entry.

Grant G62 reports \$48,000 spent in the quarter: personnel \$30,000, materials \$12,000, and travel \$6,000. The reporting instructions request these categories and supporting records. The currently assembled records support personnel \$29,000, materials \$12,000, and travel \$6,000, totaling \$47,000. One \$1,000 personnel item lacks the requested supporting record. Grant officer Sana and finance coordinator Owen must flag the evidence gap, seek the missing record, and follow the actual correction and submission process. The difference alone does not establish fraud, allowability, or authority to move the amount into another category.

PEOPLE / Sana: Grant officer | Owen: Finance coordinator

USE NEUTRAL DISCREPANCY LANGUAGE

A missing record may lead to several possible explanations. State the amount, category, and evidence gap without accusing a colleague or making the problem disappear. A clear reconciliation lets the responsible reviewer decide what needs correction or further support.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What total do the assembled supporting records substantiate?

- | | |
|-------------------|-------------------|
| A \$30,000 | B \$47,000 |
| C \$48,000 | D \$46,000 |

2. Where is the evidence gap?

- | | |
|------------------------------------|---|
| A A \$1,000 personnel item | B All travel costs |
| C A \$12,000 materials item | D An unexplained \$6,000 surplus |

3. What conclusion is not established by the difference alone?

- | | |
|---|--|
| A A difference between reported and supported totals | B Fraud or cost allowability |
| C A need to reconcile the report | D A personnel documentation gap |

Answers and explanations: page 91.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

grant award

Funding provided under specified terms for an approved purpose.

IN USE identify the grant award

recipient

The entity receiving an award directly from the awarding body.

IN USE identify the recipient

subrecipient

An entity carrying out part of an award under a subaward.

IN USE monitor the subrecipient

pass-through entity

An entity providing a subaward from funding it has received.

IN USE contact the pass-through entity

award terms

The conditions governing a particular funding award.

IN USE review the award terms

reporting period

The time interval covered by a report.

IN USE confirm the reporting period

expenditure

An amount spent or recognized as spent under the applicable basis.

IN USE report expenditures

budget category

A defined grouping of planned or reported costs.

IN USE reconcile budget categories

personnel cost

Cost associated with staff work under the applicable accounting rules.

IN USE document personnel costs

source documentation

Original or supporting records substantiating a transaction.

IN USE obtain source documentation

supporting schedule

A detailed breakdown supporting a reported figure.

IN USE prepare a supporting schedule

general ledger

The main accounting record organizing transactions by account.

IN USE reconcile the general ledger

Precision check

A reported total can add correctly while its supporting evidence remains incomplete. Here the category figures total \$48,000, but the assembled support totals \$47,000. The discrepancy is specifically a \$1,000 personnel item, not a general arithmetic error.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

reconciliation

Comparison of records to identify and explain differences.

IN USE complete the reconciliation

variance

A difference between compared figures or positions.

IN USE explain the variance

unsupported item

An item lacking the evidence required for the stated review.

IN USE flag an unsupported item

allowable cost

A cost permitted under the applicable rules and award terms.

IN USE assess cost allowability

allocable cost

A cost assignable to an activity under the applicable benefit relationship.

IN USE assess cost allocability

cost share

The portion of project costs met from sources specified outside the award funding.

IN USE document cost share

indirect cost

A cost supporting multiple activities rather than one readily identified objective.

IN USE review indirect costs

obligation

A commitment creating a requirement to pay under the applicable definition.

IN USE distinguish obligations from expenditures

unobligated balance

Funds not committed through obligations under the applicable accounting basis.

IN USE report the unobligated balance

certification

An authorized attestation about specified information or compliance.

IN USE review the certification

corrected report

A revised submission fixing identified reporting errors.

IN USE submit a corrected report

closeout

The process of completing award-end administrative and financial requirements.

IN USE prepare for closeout

Precision check

Documented does not automatically mean allowable, and unsupported does not automatically mean fraudulent. Obtain the required evidence and follow the actual review process. Do not move a cost between categories merely to make the report appear balanced.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

IDENTIFY THE AWARD

"We are reconciling the quarterly report for G62."

STATE THE SUPPORTED TOTAL

"The assembled records support forty-seven thousand dollars."

SEPARATE ARITHMETIC FROM EVIDENCE

"The categories add correctly, but the supporting record is incomplete."

AVOID AN ACCUSATION

"The gap does not by itself establish fraud."

STATE THE REPORTED TOTAL

"The report shows forty-eight thousand dollars."

LOCATE THE DIFFERENCE

"The one-thousand-dollar gap is in personnel."

REQUEST THE MISSING RECORD

"Please locate the record for that specific personnel item."

PRESERVE THE CLASSIFICATION

"Do not move the amount into travel just to balance the report."

Support

Describes what the evidence substantiates, not merely what a spreadsheet states.

In personnel

Locates the discrepancy in a specific category.

Does not by itself

Limits a conclusion to what the evidence actually establishes.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

CHECK THE REPORTING BASIS

"Are these figures for the same award, period, and accounting basis?"

KEEP THE GAP VISIBLE

"Mark the item as unresolved in the reconciliation."

AVOID FALSE CERTIFICATION

"We should not certify completeness while this required support is missing."

RETAIN THE RECORD

"Keep the original figures and any authorized correction traceable."

QUALIFY ALLOWABILITY

"Supporting documentation does not alone settle cost allowability."

ASK ABOUT CORRECTION

"What does the applicable process require before submission?"

ASSIGN THE FOLLOW-UP

"Owen will trace the item and return the evidence status."

CLOSE THE REVIEW

"The final report should match the approved treatment and supporting records."

Just to balance

Identifies an improper reason for changing classification.

Same award, period, and basis

Makes the reconciliation compare like with like.

Any authorized correction

Preserves the distinction between finding an issue and deciding its treatment.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which reconciliation statement is correct?

- A** Both reported and supported expenditure are \$48,000.
- B** Travel is short by \$1,000.
- C** The report has a \$1,000 addition error.
- D** Reported expenditure is \$48,000; assembled support is \$47,000, with \$1,000 unresolved in personnel.

2. What should Owen do first with the specific gap?

- A** Trace the personnel item and seek the missing support.
- B** Add \$1,000 to travel without evidence.
- C** Delete the item silently from every record.
- D** Declare fraud before investigating.

3. Which statement about allowability is sound?

- A** A balanced spreadsheet alone establishes allowability.
- B** It requires review under the applicable rules and award terms.
- C** Every ledger entry is automatically allowable.
- D** Missing support proves the cost is forbidden in every program.

4. What should a correction preserve?

- A** A different category chosen to hide the gap
- B** An unsupported completeness certification
- C** A traceable record of the original figure, reason, approval, and revised treatment
- D** Only the final number with no explanation

Answers and explanations: page 91.

The total matches the spreadsheet, not the evidence

E Conversations / turns 1-10

04

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

Allowable cost / certification / reporting period / reconciliation / source documentation / budget category / supporting schedule / variance / corrected report / unsupported item

- 01 **Sana:** I cannot tie G62 to the evidence folder. The report says forty-eight thousand; I can support forty-seven. Can we work through the category totals together?
- 02 **Owen:** The ¹ _____ shows thirty thousand for personnel, twelve thousand for materials, and six thousand for travel. Those figures add correctly to the reported total.
- 03 **Sana:** The records I have show twenty-nine thousand for personnel. Materials and travel match the schedule. Is there another personnel record somewhere?
- 04 **Owen:** We are missing ² _____ for one thousand dollars in that category. I need to trace the specific item rather than assume it belongs in the folder.
- 05 **Sana:** Then the issue is not that the spreadsheet added the categories incorrectly. It is that the evidence does not yet support every reported item.
- 06 **Owen:** Correct. The ³ _____ should show forty-eight thousand reported, forty-seven thousand supported, and one thousand unresolved in personnel. That is the clearest description of the current position.
- 07 **Sana:** Someone suggested moving the thousand into travel because that category has room in the budget. That would make the report look less awkward.
- 08 **Owen:** Available budget does not determine the ⁴ _____ of an actual transaction. We should not reclassify the item simply to remove the visible gap. The treatment needs evidence and the proper review.
- 09 **Sana:** The draft issue note calls it fraud. All we know so far is that the record is missing. I want the wording to reflect that distinction.
- 10 **Owen:** Call it an ⁵ _____ at this stage. Missing support does not by itself establish intent. We can state exactly what is absent and what we are doing to obtain it.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

04

Continue with the word bank on page 37.

- 11 **Sana:** If you find the record, does that automatically settle whether the grant can pay for the cost?
- 12 **Owen:** No. ⁶ _____ status depends on the applicable rules and award terms as well. The record supports the transaction; the reviewer still needs the relevant basis for charging it to the award.
- 13 **Sana:** Before comparing the figures again, please confirm that we are using the same quarter and the same accounting basis.
- 14 **Owen:** I will check the ⁷ _____ and the award reference. We should not reconcile a current-quarter total against a folder containing a different period and then explain the wrong discrepancy.
- 15 **Sana:** The submission includes a completeness certification. I do not want us to sign it while ignoring a required missing record.
- 16 **Owen:** We should flag that before ⁸ _____. I will return the evidence status and ask what the actual correction and submission process requires, rather than choosing a treatment on my own.
- 17 **Sana:** If a correction is authorized, keep the original report and the reason for the change. We need a clear history.
- 18 **Owen:** Agreed. A ⁹ _____ should be traceable to the review decision. Quietly replacing the number would make it harder to understand what happened and whether the issue was actually resolved.
- 19 **Sana:** Please send the specific item reference, the missing evidence, and your follow-up status to me before we finalize the submission.
- 20 **Owen:** I will keep the ¹⁰ _____ visible until it is resolved through that process. We can be precise about the gap without either hiding it or claiming more than the evidence shows.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 92

1. supporting schedule | 2. source documentation | 3. reconciliation | 4. budget category | 5. unsupported item | 6. Allowable cost | 7. reporting period | 8. certification | 9. corrected report | 10. variance

Reconcile another grant total

F Say it

Grant K9 reports personnel \$18,000, materials \$7,000, and travel \$3,000. Assembled support is \$18,000, \$6,500, and \$3,000 respectively. One materials record remains missing.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

\$500 / materials / \$28,000 / \$27,500

Officer: "The reported total is ¹ _____."

Coordinator: "The supported total is ² _____."

Officer: "The unresolved difference is ³ _____."

Coordinator: "The affected category is ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 92

1. \$28,000 | 2. \$27,500 | 3. \$500 | 4. materials

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8, distinguishing the reported amount from the supported amount.
2. Swap roles for turns 9-20; keep the unresolved item neutral and specific.
3. Complete the K9 reconciliation and check that its difference belongs to materials, not personnel.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Everyone is involved, but nobody has called the resident

A Read the situation

Assign distinct responsibilities across agencies and confirm a handoff without implying that the underlying service is approved.

Request Q41 concerns accessible transport to a community appointment. The Community Office reviews program eligibility; the Transit Office checks vehicle availability and booking feasibility. Each office assumed the other would contact the resident. During a coordination call, Jon from Community agrees to own the resident update at 15:00 local time. Aisha from Transit will send an availability status to Jon by 14:30. Eligibility and a booking both remain unconfirmed. The authorized initial handoff needs the request reference, pickup zone, and requested time window, not the resident's full medical file.

PEOPLE / Jon: Community Office coordinator | Aisha: Transit Office coordinator

SHARED WORK STILL NEEDS NAMED ACTIONS

Saying we are handling it can hide a gap between organizations. Assign one person to each action and repeat the recipient, deadline, and expected result. Keep responsibility for communicating progress distinct from authority to approve eligibility or confirm a booking.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Who owns the resident update?

- A** The resident's appointment provider
- B** Jon at 15:00 local time
- C** Aisha at an unspecified time
- D** Both offices without a named lead

2. What will Transit provide by 14:30?

- A** A guaranteed completed trip
- B** A Community eligibility decision
- C** The resident's full medical file
- D** An availability status to Jon

3. What remains unconfirmed?

- A** Eligibility and the transport booking
- B** The Q41 reference
- C** The named resident-contact owner
- D** The agreed internal update time

Answers and explanations: [page 93](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

interagency

Involving two or more public agencies.

IN USE coordinate interagency work

lead contact

The named person coordinating communication for a matter.

IN USE appoint a lead contact

referring office

The office sending a matter to another responsible team.

IN USE identify the referring office

receiving office

The office to which a matter is transferred.

IN USE confirm the receiving office

responsibility matrix

A record mapping tasks to their responsible owners.

IN USE update the responsibility matrix

action owner

The named person accountable for a specific next action.

IN USE assign an action owner

handoff

Transfer of a task, information, or responsibility between teams.

IN USE confirm the handoff

acknowledgment of receipt

Confirmation that information has arrived.

IN USE request acknowledgment of receipt

acceptance of responsibility

Confirmation that a person or team has taken ownership of a task.

IN USE record acceptance of responsibility

service dependency

A prerequisite affecting whether a service can proceed.

IN USE identify service dependencies

availability check

A review of whether the needed resource or slot can be supplied.

IN USE complete an availability check

booking confirmation

Notice that a specific service arrangement is reserved or agreed.

IN USE issue booking confirmation

Precision check

Receipt means a message arrived. Acceptance of responsibility means someone has agreed to perform the next task. Neither proves that the resident is eligible or that a vehicle is booked. Record these different statuses separately in the shared request record.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

eligibility review

Assessment against the program's qualification requirements.

IN USE complete the eligibility review

request reference

An identifier linking records to the same service request.

IN USE quote the request reference

pickup zone

The defined area from which a transport pickup is requested.

IN USE confirm the pickup zone

requested window

The time period asked for before scheduling is confirmed.

IN USE record the requested window

data-sharing authority

The applicable basis permitting a defined information transfer.

IN USE verify data-sharing authority

minimum necessary data

Information limited to what is needed for the stated authorized purpose.

IN USE share the minimum necessary data

purpose limitation

Restricting information use to the defined permitted purpose.

IN USE observe purpose limitation

secure channel

An approved communication route with appropriate safeguards.

IN USE use the secure channel

joint status

A coordinated account of progress across participating teams.

IN USE prepare a joint status

escalation contact

The person designated for unresolved or urgent coordination issues.

IN USE identify the escalation contact

dependency tracker

A record of prerequisites, owners, and their status.

IN USE maintain the dependency tracker

closed-loop handoff

A transfer in which receipt and next responsibility are confirmed.

IN USE complete a closed-loop handoff

Precision check

Share information under the applicable authority and safeguards, limited to the task. Here the authorized initial exchange needs a reference, pickup zone, and requested window. Do not attach a full medical file merely because both teams are public agencies.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

NAME THE GAP

"Each office assumed the other would contact the resident."

ASSIGN THE LEAD

"Jon will own the resident update."

SET THE EXTERNAL TIME

"The resident update is at 15:00 local time."

SET THE INTERNAL TIME

"Transit will send its status to Jon by 14:30."

DEFINE THE TASK

"We are checking availability, not confirming a booking yet."

KEEP THE ELIGIBILITY BOUNDARY

"Community retains the eligibility review."

SEPARATE RECEIPT FROM OWNERSHIP

"Has the receiving office accepted the task, or only received the message?"

USE THE REFERENCE

"Please quote Q41 in both records."

Own the update

Assigns communication accountability without granting decision authority.

By 14:30

Gives the internal contribution a deadline before the resident contact.

Not ... yet

Prevents an investigation task from being mistaken for a completed result.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

LIMIT THE TRANSFER

"The initial handoff needs the pickup zone and requested window."

CHECK PERMISSION AND METHOD

"Use the authorized data-sharing route and approved channel."

HANDLE AN INCOMPLETE RESULT

"Report the open question even if availability is not confirmed by then."

READ BACK OWNERSHIP

"Aisha checks availability; Jon updates the resident."

AVOID EXCESS INFORMATION

"The full medical file is not needed for this exchange."

CONFIRM THE RECIPIENT

"Send the availability status to Jon, not directly to an unassigned inbox."

NAME ESCALATION

"Who should we contact if the internal update is missed?"

CLOSE THE LOOP

"Please confirm receipt and the next action in the request record."

Retains

Keeps an existing responsibility with the correct office.

Only received

Distinguishes message delivery from task ownership.

Even if

Preserves the update commitment when the underlying answer remains incomplete.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which handoff is complete?

- A** Sending an email alone proves the resident has a booking.
- B** Jon transfers every responsibility without acceptance.
- C** Aisha sends the availability status by 14:30; Jon confirms receipt and updates the resident at 15:00.
- D** Both offices assume someone else will call.

2. Which statement preserves the agencies' roles?

- A** Transit automatically decides Community eligibility.
- B** Community guarantees a vehicle without asking Transit.
- C** Both reviews are complete because the request has a number.
- D** Community reviews eligibility; Transit checks availability.

3. Which information belongs in the authorized initial exchange?

- A** Every resident record held by either office
- B** Request reference, pickup zone, and requested window
- C** The full medical file by default
- D** All unrelated case notes

4. What should happen if availability remains unknown at 14:30?

- A** Both offices stay silent until a booking exists.
- B** Jon announces a guaranteed vehicle anyway.
- C** The resident-contact task silently disappears.
- D** Aisha sends that status and the open question so Jon can give the promised update.

Answers and explanations: [page 93](#).

Everyone is involved, but nobody has called the resident

E Conversations / turns 1-10

05

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

acknowledgment of receipt / lead contact / eligibility review / escalation contact / secure channel / joint status / closed-loop handoff / request reference / availability check / action owner

- 01 **Jon:** We have a gap on Q41. The resident has heard from neither office. Our note says Transit to contact, but I cannot find an accepted handoff.
- 02 **Aisha:** We thought Community was the ¹ _____. Let us assign that explicitly now rather than leave another shared note that neither office owns.
- 03 **Jon:** I will update the resident at 15:00 local time. I need your availability position early enough to explain what is still open.
- 04 **Aisha:** I will be the ² _____ for the Transit status and send it to you by 14:30. That gives you a defined input before your contact.
- 05 **Jon:** Is that a booking confirmation, or simply the result of the availability check at that point?
- 06 **Aisha:** It is an ³ _____ status. We have not confirmed a vehicle or a booking. I will distinguish available, unavailable, and still under review rather than use the vague word arranged.
- 07 **Jon:** Community still needs to complete its program review. I do not want either team to imply that the transport request itself establishes eligibility.
- 08 **Aisha:** Keep the ⁴ _____ with Community. Transit can report its resource position, but that does not replace your office's decision or remove the other service dependencies.
- 09 **Jon:** What do you need in the initial handoff? The file contains personal details that may not be relevant to checking a possible slot.
- 10 **Aisha:** Under the authorized exchange, send the ⁵ _____, pickup zone, and requested time window. We do not need the full medical file for that initial task.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 46.

- 11 **Jon:** I will use the approved channel and keep the information limited to that purpose. Should I send it to your personal work queue?
- 12 **Aisha:** Yes, through the designated ⁶ _____. I will confirm that it arrived and that I have accepted the availability task, not just that the message is visible.
- 13 **Jon:** That is where we lost the thread last time. Sent appeared in the record, and everyone read it as taken over. I will separate those statuses.
- 14 **Aisha:** An ⁷ _____ alone would not show ownership. I will record the next action and its deadline so your team can see what I have actually agreed to do.
- 15 **Jon:** If you still cannot confirm availability at 14:30, please tell me that rather than wait until you have a final answer.
- 16 **Aisha:** Agreed. The ⁸ _____ can explain the open questions. You should be able to give the resident the promised update even if the booking decision is still pending.
- 17 **Jon:** We also need a route if the internal update is missed or a dependency cannot be resolved within the available time.
- 18 **Aisha:** I will identify the ⁹ _____ in the record. That is a coordination route, not a promise to override eligibility requirements or create capacity that does not exist.
- 19 **Jon:** Let me read it back: you send the availability status by 14:30; I own the resident update at 15:00. Eligibility and booking remain unconfirmed.
- 20 **Aisha:** Correct. That is a ¹⁰ _____. I will confirm the transfer in Q41 and keep my status separate from any booking confirmation so both offices communicate the same position.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 94

1. lead contact | 2. action owner | 3. availability check | 4. eligibility review | 5. request reference | 6. secure channel | 7. acknowledgment of receipt | 8. joint status | 9. escalation contact | 10. closed-loop handoff

Assign a second interagency update

F Say it

For R52, Housing checks program eligibility and Mobility checks vehicle availability. Mobility officer Bea sends status to Housing officer Eli by 10:00. Eli contacts the resident at 10:30 local time. No booking is confirmed.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

10:30 local time / Eli / Bea / 10:00

Coordinator: "The internal status owner is ¹ _____."

Officer: "The internal update deadline is ² _____."

Coordinator: "The resident-contact owner is ³ _____."

Officer: "The resident update is at ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 94

1. Bea | 2. 10:00 | 3. Eli | 4. 10:30 local time

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8 and give the two update times distinct emphasis.
2. Swap roles for turns 9-20; pause after the named recipient and accepted next action.
3. Complete the R52 handoff below and read back each owner with the correct deadline.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

A referral that does not send the resident in circles

A Read the situation

Repair a misdirected service request by explaining jurisdiction, confirming a referral, and preserving a separate complaint route.

06

Resident business owner Tessa has contacted three offices about placing a bench outside her shop. Licensing handles business registration, not permission to use the public sidewalk. Under this fictional town's process, Public Works Permit Intake receives the site plan and routes the sidewalk-use application for review. Service officer Ben has not yet confirmed that intake has accepted Tessa's referral. Ben can seek confirmation and call her Wednesday at 10:00 local time. That is a follow-up commitment, not a permit decision deadline. Her complaint about repeated redirection should be recorded separately from the permit application.

PEOPLE / Tessa: Resident business owner | Ben: Constituent service officer

EXPLAIN THE REASON FOR THE REFERRAL

Another office name can sound like another rejection unless the resident understands its role. Acknowledge the repeated redirection, explain the receiving office's function, and confirm the handoff. Avoid promising a permit as compensation for a frustrating service experience.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which office receives the site plan under this process?

A Business Licensing

B The service officer's personal mailbox as a final decision route

C An unspecified fourth office

D Public Works Permit Intake

2. What is Ben's Wednesday 10:00 commitment?

A A follow-up call about the referral

B Guaranteed permit approval

C Completion of all site inspections

D Automatic acceptance of the site plan

3. How should the redirection complaint be recorded?

A As proof that the permit must be granted

B As withdrawal of the application

C Only if Tessa stops asking about the bench

D Separately from the permit application

Answers and explanations: page 95.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

constituent service

Assistance connecting people with public processes or offices.

IN USE provide constituent service

jurisdiction

The scope of an office's legal or assigned responsibility.

IN USE clarify jurisdiction

service remit

The defined matters an office handles.

IN USE explain the service remit

intake office

The unit receiving and initially routing requests or applications.

IN USE identify the intake office

referral

Direction or transfer of a matter to a relevant person or office.

IN USE make a referral

warm referral

A supported transfer that helps connect the person to the receiving office.

IN USE arrange a warm referral

referral acceptance

Confirmation that the receiving office has taken the referred matter.

IN USE verify referral acceptance

case summary

A concise account of the issue and relevant history.

IN USE prepare a case summary

service history

The record of contacts and actions concerning a service matter.

IN USE review the service history

business registration

Recording a business under the applicable registration process.

IN USE verify business registration

sidewalk-use permit

Permission under a local process for a specified use of a public sidewalk.

IN USE apply for a sidewalk-use permit

site plan

A drawing showing the location and layout relevant to a proposal.

IN USE submit a site plan

Precision check

Registration of a business does not automatically authorize use of public space. The fictional town assigns the sidewalk application to Public Works Permit Intake. Explain that role clearly, but do not present the same office structure or permit process as universal.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

application receipt

Confirmation that an application has arrived.

IN USE confirm application receipt

completeness review

Assessment of whether the required application items are present.

IN USE conduct a completeness review

substantive review

Assessment of the application's merits against the relevant requirements.

IN USE await substantive review

permit condition

A requirement attached to an issued permission.

IN USE explain permit conditions

follow-up call

A later contact to provide status or continue handling a matter.

IN USE schedule a follow-up call

response target

A planned time for a defined response.

IN USE state the response target

decision deadline

A time by which a decision is due under the applicable process.

IN USE verify the decision deadline

service complaint

A complaint about the handling or quality of a public service.

IN USE record a service complaint

complaint reference

An identifier for a complaint record.

IN USE provide the complaint reference

review route

The process for obtaining further examination of a matter.

IN USE explain the review route

case continuity

Preservation of relevant information across contacts or transfers.

IN USE maintain case continuity

closure reason

The documented explanation for closing a service record.

IN USE record the closure reason

Precision check

Application receipt, completeness review, substantive review, and permission are different stages. A supported referral can reduce repeated explanation without guaranteeing the result. Keep a service complaint separate so that acknowledging poor handling does not pre-decide the permit.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE HISTORY

"You have already been redirected repeatedly."

EXPLAIN THE FIRST OFFICE

"Licensing handles business registration."

NAME THE NEEDED ITEM

"The stated intake process asks for a site plan."

CHECK THE TRANSFER

"Has Permit Intake accepted the referral?"

TAKE RESPONSIBILITY FOR CLARIFICATION

"I will confirm the correct intake route before sending you elsewhere."

EXPLAIN THE RECEIVING OFFICE

"Public Works Permit Intake receives the sidewalk-use application."

AVOID IMPLIED PERMISSION

"Business registration does not itself authorize this sidewalk use."

OFFER CONTINUITY

"With the appropriate authorization, I will pass on the relevant case summary."

06

Already been redirected

Recognizes the resident's actual service history.

Before sending

Makes verification a prerequisite to another referral.

Does not itself

Limits what one administrative action establishes.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

LIMIT PERSONAL INFORMATION

"I will use only the details needed for this referral."

DEFINE THE COMMITMENT

"That call will report the referral status, not guarantee a permit decision."

AVOID COMPENSATION BY APPROVAL

"The service problem does not authorize me to grant the permit."

PROVIDE A REFERENCE

"I will give you the reference and responsible contact once confirmed."

STATE THE FOLLOW-UP

"I will call Wednesday at 10:00 local time."

KEEP THE COMPLAINT SEPARATE

"I will record the redirection complaint separately from the application."

EXPLAIN THE NEXT STAGE

"Receipt is followed by the applicable completeness and substantive review."

CLOSE ACCURATELY

"I will not mark the matter resolved merely because an email was sent."

06

Accepted the referral

Checks ownership rather than only message delivery.

Report ... not guarantee

Defines a realistic follow-up commitment.

Separately from

Keeps the complaint and application processes distinct.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which explanation gives a useful referral?

- A** Your complaint means no application is needed.
- B** Licensing handles registration; Public Works Permit Intake receives the sidewalk application and site plan.
- C** Try another office; they probably know.
- D** Registration automatically permits every sidewalk use.

2. Which follow-up statement is accurate?

- A** Receipt means every permit condition is satisfied.
- B** A sent email proves the intake team accepted the case.
- C** I will call Wednesday at 10:00 local time with the referral status.
- D** Your permit will be approved by Wednesday at 10:00.

3. What preserves case continuity?

- A** An authorized relevant summary and confirmation of the receiving contact
- B** Requiring the resident to restart without checking the record
- C** Sending unrelated personal files to every office
- D** Closing the case when the first email leaves

4. How should the complaint affect the permit decision?

- A** It should be handled separately, without pre-deciding the permit.
- B** It automatically guarantees approval.
- C** It automatically disqualifies the applicant.
- D** It replaces the site plan.

Answers and explanations: page 95.

A referral that does not send the resident in circles

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

Referral acceptance / follow-up call / site plan / decision deadline / case continuity / service complaint / case summary / closure reason / service remit / sidewalk-use permit

- 01 **Tessa:** I have explained this bench three times. Licensing sent me elsewhere, and I was sent back. Before I join another queue, can someone tell me who actually handles it?
- 02 **Ben:** I am sorry about the repeated redirection. Let us clarify the
1 _____ before I send you anywhere else. Licensing handles business registration, which is different from permission to use the public sidewalk.
- 03 **Tessa:** My business is registered, so I thought that office could confirm whether the bench is allowed outside the shop.
- 04 **Ben:** A 2 _____ follows a different process here. Public Works Permit Intake receives that application and the site plan, then routes it for the relevant review.
- 05 **Tessa:** I have a drawing showing where the bench would go and how much space would remain. Is that the document they need first?
- 06 **Ben:** The stated intake item is a 3 _____. I can confirm their submission requirements, but I should not say your drawing is complete or approved before the receiving team checks it.
- 07 **Tessa:** Can you transfer the information I have already given? I do not want to start the story again with a fourth person.
- 08 **Ben:** With the appropriate authorization, I can pass on a relevant
4 _____. I will include the bench request and previous contacts, using only the details needed for this referral through the approved route.
- 09 **Tessa:** That would help. But is someone at Public Works taking it on, or will I arrive with another email that nobody has picked up?
- 10 **Ben:** 5 _____ is not confirmed yet. I will seek that confirmation and identify the responsible contact instead of treating an outgoing email as a completed handoff.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 55.

- 11 **Tessa:** When will I hear from you? I need something more specific than soon because I am planning the shop opening.
- 12 **Ben:** I can make a ⁶ _____ on Wednesday at 10:00 local time. I will tell you whether intake has accepted the referral and what the next step is.
- 13 **Tessa:** Does that mean I will have a permit decision by Wednesday morning, or only information about where the application stands?
- 14 **Ben:** Only the status update. A ⁷ _____ for the permit has not been established here. Receipt, completeness review, and substantive review are different stages, and I cannot collapse them into that call.
- 15 **Tessa:** I also want the repeated redirection recorded as a complaint. That has cost time even if the permit process still has work to do.
- 16 **Ben:** I will record a separate ⁸ _____ about the handling. That does not replace your application or decide whether the bench meets the requirements, but the service concern should be addressed.
- 17 **Tessa:** Please keep both references clear. I do not want the complaint to cause the application to disappear from the system.
- 18 **Ben:** I will maintain ⁹ _____ while distinguishing the records. When the references and receiving contact are confirmed, I will explain which one to quote for each purpose.
- 19 **Tessa:** Then I will expect your Wednesday call about the referral, and the complaint will follow its own review route.
- 20 **Ben:** Correct. I will not use sent an email as the ¹⁰ _____ for a resolved case. The record should show the actual handoff status, the remaining action, and who owns it.

06

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 96

1. service remit | 2. sidewalk-use permit | 3. site plan | 4. case summary | 5. Referral acceptance | 6. follow-up call | 7. decision deadline | 8. service complaint | 9. case continuity | 10. closure reason

Repair another referral

F Say it

For a fictional street-banner application, Events Registration records the event but Road Use Intake receives the banner plan. Officer Hana promises a referral-status call on Thursday at 14:00 local time. No permit decision is promised.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

referral status / Thursday at 14:00 local time / Road Use Intake / Hana

Resident: "The office receiving the banner plan is ¹ _____."

Officer: "The promised follow-up owner is ² _____."

Resident: "The call is scheduled for ³ _____."

Officer: "The call concerns ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 96

1. Road Use Intake | 2. Hana | 3. Thursday at 14:00 local time | 4. referral status

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10, acknowledging the repeated referral without promising a permit.
2. Swap roles for turns 11-20 and distinguish the application from the service complaint.
3. Complete the banner referral below; read the call commitment without turning it into an approval date.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Found records are not automatically cleared records

A Read the situation

Explain a federal records-review status without promising full release or using a possible exemption as a blanket refusal.

A fictional U.S. federal agency receives request F77 for signed service contracts and their attachments from January through March. Staff locate eight responsive contract files. Two contain personal contact details requiring review; no release or withholding decision has been made. An initial acknowledgment mistakenly promises that every page will be released automatically. Records officer Imani and program liaison Cole must correct the promise, preserve the records, and explain the review process. The presence of potentially protected information does not itself authorize withholding an entire file. Applicable disclosure standards and any partial release must be assessed by the responsible staff.

PEOPLE / Imani: Records officer | Cole: Program liaison

07

TRANSPARENCY NEEDS ACCURATE STATUS LANGUAGE

A requester can deserve a clear explanation even when review is unfinished. Distinguish records found from records cleared for release. Do not use privacy as a vague excuse, but do not promise to disclose personal details before the appropriate review.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What has been established?

- A** Every page has been cleared for release.
- B** All eight files must be withheld.
- C** No records exist.
- D** Eight responsive contract files have been located.

2. What needs correction?

- A** The promise of automatic full release
- B** The January-through-March request scope
- C** The number eight without contrary evidence
- D** The need to preserve responsive records

3. What follows from personal details appearing in two files?

- A** Every page must be released without review.
- B** The entire request can be treated as nonexistent.
- C** Those details require review; full-file withholding is not automatic.
- D** Both files are automatically excluded in full.

Answers and explanations: [page 97](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

FOIA

Freedom of Information Act; the U.S. federal records-access law.

IN USE process a FOIA request

records request

A request for access to identified or described records.

IN USE clarify a records request

request scope

The boundaries of the records sought.

IN USE confirm the request scope

responsive record

A record falling within the request's description.

IN USE identify responsive records

records custodian

The person or unit responsible for relevant records.

IN USE contact the records custodian

search terms

Words or criteria used to locate relevant records.

IN USE document the search terms

date range

The start and end period limiting a search or request.

IN USE confirm the date range

attachment

A file or document included with another record.

IN USE review the attachments

acknowledgment

A response confirming receipt of a request.

IN USE issue an acknowledgment

tracking number

A reference used to follow a request's progress.

IN USE quote the tracking number

disclosure review

Assessment of what information can or must be released.

IN USE conduct disclosure review

exemption

A legal provision potentially permitting or requiring specified information to be withheld.

IN USE assess an exemption

Precision check

Responsive means within the request scope; it does not mean cleared for release. The eight files match the stated contract request. Personal details in two files require review, but their presence alone does not decide the fate of every page.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

foreseeable harm

The expected harm considered under the applicable federal withholding standard.

IN USE assess foreseeable harm

redaction

Removal or masking of protected information from a released copy.

IN USE apply justified redactions

segregable information

Information that can be separated from protected material for release.

IN USE identify segregable information

partial release

Disclosure of releasable portions while other information is withheld under an applicable basis.

IN USE prepare a partial release

withholding basis

The legal and factual reason supporting nondisclosure.

IN USE document the withholding basis

personal privacy

An individual's interest in protection of personal information.

IN USE assess personal-privacy interests

release copy

The version prepared for disclosure after the applicable review.

IN USE verify the release copy

records preservation

Keeping records intact under applicable requirements.

IN USE maintain records preservation

retention schedule

A rule or policy governing how long records are retained and disposed of.

IN USE follow the retention schedule

administrative appeal

A request for agency-level review of an initial decision.

IN USE explain the administrative appeal route

public liaison

A designated contact helping requesters understand or resolve process concerns.

IN USE contact the public liaison

review status

The current position of an assessment before or after a decision.

IN USE explain the review status

Precision check

For U.S. federal requests, responsible reviewers assess the applicable disclosure and withholding standards, including partial disclosure where appropriate. Do not use a possible exemption as a blanket refusal or quietly change source records to simplify a release.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

STATE THE SEARCH RESULT

"We located eight responsive contract files."

SEPARATE STAGES

"Located does not mean cleared for release."

DESCRIBE THE PENDING REVIEW

"Two files contain personal details that require review."

ASK FOR THE BASIS

"What applicable legal and factual basis supports the proposed withholding?"

RETAIN THE REQUEST SCOPE

"The request covers signed contracts and attachments from January through March."

CORRECT THE EARLIER PROMISE

"The acknowledgment should not have promised automatic full disclosure."

AVOID A BLANKET REFUSAL

"Their presence does not automatically justify withholding the entire files."

CHECK PARTIAL DISCLOSURE

"Which information can be separated and released?"

Located does not mean

Separates a search result from a disclosure decision.

Should not have promised

Corrects a prior overstatement directly.

Require review

Identifies the next task without pre-deciding the result.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

PRESERVE THE SOURCE

"Keep the original records intact under the applicable requirements."

AVOID AN INVENTED DATE

"We should provide the actual process status, not an unsupported release deadline."

EXPLAIN RESPONSIBILITY

"The records team will make the disclosure assessment."

PROVIDE THE RELEVANT ROUTE

"The response should explain the applicable review or appeal information."

DISTINGUISH THE COPY

"Any justified redactions belong in the reviewed release copy."

KEEP THE REFERENCE

"Please use F77 in the correction and subsequent updates."

DOCUMENT THE REASONING

"Retain the review decision and its supporting basis."

CLOSE ACCURATELY

"We can report progress without predicting an unmade disclosure decision."

Legal and factual basis

Requests both the applicable provision and the reason it fits.

Can be separated

Focuses on releasable information rather than treating a file as indivisible.

Unmade decision

Prevents a progress message from implying that review has finished.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which update is accurate?

- A** Eight responsive files were located; disclosure review remains underway.
- B** Eight files were found, so every page is automatically public.
- C** Two personal details justify refusing every record.
- D** The search found nothing because review is incomplete.

2. How should the earlier acknowledgment be handled?

- A** Correct the automatic-release promise and explain the actual review status.
- B** Wait for final review before mentioning the inaccurate promise.
- C** Replace the promise with a full-withholding notice for the two files.
- D** Reissue a receipt notice without acknowledging the earlier assurance.

3. What is the right response to a proposed full-file withholding?

- A** Ask for the applicable basis and assess whether releasable portions can be separated.
- B** Accept it solely because one page contains contact details.
- C** Assume all personal information must always be published.
- D** Stop preserving the file because release is uncertain.

4. What should remain intact?

- A** No records once a possible exemption is noticed
- B** The source records under applicable preservation requirements
- C** Only the final email to the requester
- D** A rewritten original with inconvenient details removed

Answers and explanations: [page 97](#).

Found records are not automatically cleared records

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

administrative appeal / segregable information / request scope / review status / acknowledgment / partial release / responsive records / redaction / exemption / records preservation

07

- 01 **Cole:** I need to correct our F77 acknowledgment. We located eight files, but the letter promised every page. Two contain personal contact details that have not been reviewed.
- 02 **Imani:** First separate ¹ _____ from records cleared for disclosure. The files match the request, but the release assessment is not finished. That acknowledgment promises more than we can support.
- 03 **Cole:** The request is for signed service contracts and their attachments from January through March. We have not been asked for every email about the projects.
- 04 **Imani:** Keep that ² _____ visible in the record. We should not silently broaden or narrow the request, and any genuine ambiguity should be handled through the appropriate clarification process.
- 05 **Cole:** I can flag the affected files for review. I would rather not send a blanket withholding message before anyone has looked at the individual details. Is that right?
- 06 **Imani:** Yes. A possible ³ _____ needs review against the actual information and applicable standard. Personal details do not automatically settle the treatment of every page in those files.
- 07 **Cole:** Then the team should distinguish the contact details from the rest of the contract material, rather than treating each file as indivisible.
- 08 **Imani:** Yes, assess ⁴ _____. The responsible reviewers must examine what can be released and document any valid withholding basis, including the relevant harm analysis where the law requires it.
- 09 **Cole:** I do not want to alter the originals while preparing the material for review. What should the program team preserve?
- 10 **Imani:** Follow ⁵ _____ requirements and keep the source records intact. Preparation of a disclosure version is not permission to rewrite or delete the originals to make the request easier to handle.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 64.

- 11 **Cole:** If the review supports removing particular details, we would work from a separate version for disclosure.
- 12 **Imani:** Correct. Any justified ⁶ _____ belongs in the reviewed release copy, with the required basis and explanation. Do not obscure material simply because it is embarrassing or inconvenient for the office.
- 13 **Cole:** The requester may feel we are changing our position after promising full release. How should I explain the correction?
- 14 **Imani:** Correct the ⁷ _____ directly. Say that the earlier automatic-release assurance was inaccurate, that eight responsive files were located, and that disclosure review is still underway.
- 15 **Cole:** Should we give a new release date now, so the correction does not sound vague?
- 16 **Imani:** Give the actual ⁸ _____ and any properly established process information. Do not invent a deadline to compensate for the earlier promise. The responsible team should confirm any applicable timing statement.
- 17 **Cole:** We will retain the file references, the decision record, and the explanation of anything ultimately withheld.
- 18 **Imani:** Also check the ⁹ _____ position where full disclosure is not possible. The response should reflect the actual review, not a blanket choice between releasing everything and releasing nothing.
- 19 **Cole:** I will route the correction through the records team and keep F77 attached to the search and review history.
- 20 **Imani:** Good. When a decision is issued, provide the applicable ¹⁰ _____ information and relevant contacts. We can be transparent about the process while leaving the substantive disclosure decision with the authorized reviewers.

07

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 98

1. responsive records | 2. request scope | 3. exemption | 4. segregable information | 5. records preservation | 6. redaction | 7. acknowledgment | 8. review status | 9. partial release | 10. administrative appeal

Describe another records-review status

F Say it

Request C44 covers final inspection reports for April. Six responsive files are found. One contains information requiring review. No release or withholding decision has been made.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

07

WORD + PHRASE BANK

April / six responsive files / not yet made / C44

Liaison: "The request reference is ¹ _____."

Officer: "The search found ² _____."

Liaison: "The requested month is ³ _____."

Officer: "The disclosure decision is ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 98

1. C44 | 2. six responsive files | 3. April | 4. not yet made

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8, distinguishing responsive records from information cleared for release.
2. Swap roles for turns 9-20; make the acknowledgment correction direct and specific.
3. Complete the C44 status exchange below and keep its unresolved decision explicit.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Twenty workshops do not prove the outcome

A Read the situation

Explain outputs, response rates, and observed outcomes while keeping a budget request separate from a causal success claim.

A fictional employment program requests \$240,000 for next year after spending \$200,000 this year. It delivered 20 workshops and recorded 400 attendances, which include repeat visits. In the previous follow-up cohort, 200 of 250 invited people responded and 80 respondents reported employment at 90 days. In the current cohort, 210 of 300 responded and 105 reported employment. The respondent employment rates are 40% and 50%, while response rates are 80% and 70%. Analyst Faye and budget officer Luis must explain the figures without counting attendances as unique people or claiming the program caused the observed change.

PEOPLE / Faye: Program analyst | Luis: Budget officer

08

A USEFUL CHALLENGE IMPROVES THE PUBLIC EXPLANATION

A budget reviewer may ask what changed for residents rather than how busy the team was. Answer with definitions, denominators, and limits. Preserve genuine activity and outcome evidence without treating a request for better measurement as dismissal of the staff's work.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What do the 400 attendances count?

- | | |
|--|------------------------------------|
| A Visits, including repeat visits | B Exactly 400 unique people |
| C Exactly 400 people gaining employment | D Only survey respondents |

2. What is the current respondent employment rate?

- | | |
|--------------|--------------|
| A 40% | B 50% |
| C 35% | D 70% |

3. How much does the requested budget exceed current spending?

- | | |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------|
| A \$240,000, or 120% | B \$40,000, or 20% |
| C \$20,000, or 10% | D \$40,000, or 40% |

Answers and explanations: page 99.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

budget justification

The evidence and reasoning supporting a funding request.

IN USE strengthen the budget justification

appropriation

Funding authority granted through the applicable legislative process.

IN USE distinguish a request from an appropriation

budget request

A proposal for future funding.

IN USE submit a budget request

actual expenditure

The amount spent under the stated accounting basis and period.

IN USE report actual expenditure

input

A resource used to deliver an activity or service.

IN USE identify program inputs

activity

Work carried out by a program.

IN USE describe program activities

output

A direct product or count of services delivered.

IN USE measure outputs

outcome

A change or result experienced by the target population.

IN USE measure outcomes

impact

A broader or causally attributed effect, depending on the evaluation definition.

IN USE assess program impact

attendance

A recorded instance of participation, which may include repeat visits.

IN USE count attendances

unique participant

A distinct person counted once within the defined scope.

IN USE count unique participants

cohort

A defined group observed over a particular period.

IN USE compare cohorts

08

Precision check

The employment rates use respondents as the denominator: $80/200 = 40\%$ and $105/210 = 50\%$. The change is ten percentage points, or 25% relative to 40%. These are observed respondent outcomes, not established results for every invited person.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

follow-up survey

A later survey collecting information after a service or event.

IN USE conduct a follow-up survey

response rate

The share of invited eligible people who provide a response under the stated definition.

IN USE calculate the response rate

respondent

A person who supplies a survey response.

IN USE identify respondents

denominator

The quantity by which another quantity is divided to calculate a rate.

IN USE state the denominator

percentage point

The unit used for the difference between two percentages.

IN USE report percentage-point change

relative change

The difference expressed as a share of the starting value.

IN USE distinguish relative change

nonresponse bias

Distortion that may arise when respondents differ systematically from nonrespondents.

IN USE assess nonresponse bias

selection effect

A difference arising from how people enter or remain in a measured group.

IN USE examine selection effects

attribution

Assignment of an observed result to a particular cause.

IN USE support causal attribution

counterfactual

An estimate of what would have happened without the intervention.

IN USE define the counterfactual

performance target

A specified intended level of achievement.

IN USE set a performance target

measurement plan

A defined approach to collecting and interpreting performance evidence.

IN USE develop the measurement plan

08

Precision check

Response rates fell from $200/250 = 80\%$ to $210/300 = 70\%$. Different response patterns can affect comparability. The workshop count and attendance total measure activity; neither proves unique reach, employment gains, or the causal effect of the program.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

STATE THE FUNDING REQUEST

"We are requesting two hundred forty thousand dollars for next year."

QUANTIFY THE INCREASE

"The request is forty thousand dollars higher, a twenty-percent increase."

KEEP THE COUNT ACCURATE

"The four hundred attendances include repeat visits."

DEFINE THE OUTCOME MEASURE

"We measured reported employment among respondents at ninety days."

COMPARE WITH ACTUAL SPENDING

"This year we spent two hundred thousand dollars."

NAME THE OUTPUT

"We delivered twenty workshops."

AVOID A REACH CLAIM

"We cannot call that four hundred unique participants."

STATE THE CURRENT DENOMINATOR

"The current rate is 105 out of 210 respondents."

08

Higher ... increase

Compares the proposed amount with the stated spending baseline.

Include repeat visits

Prevents an attendance total from becoming a unique-person claim.

Among respondents

Limits the outcome rate to the people actually measured.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

COMPARE THE RATES

"The respondent employment rate rose from forty to fifty percent."

SEPARATE RELATIVE CHANGE

"Relative to forty percent, the increase is twenty-five percent."

AVOID CAUSAL OVERSTATEMENT

"These observations do not establish that the program caused the change."

CONNECT MONEY TO DELIVERY

"The request needs a costed plan, not only a list of past activities."

USE THE CORRECT UNIT

"That is a ten-percentage-point increase."

DISCLOSE RESPONSE COVERAGE

"The response rate fell from eighty to seventy percent."

EXPLAIN THE EVIDENCE GAP

"We need better information about nonrespondents and cohort differences."

CLOSE THE JUSTIFICATION

"Show the outputs, observed outcomes, limitations, and proposed measurement plan together."

08

Percentage-point

Describes the subtraction of two percentages.

Relative to

Names the baseline used for a proportional change.

Do not establish ... caused

Separates observed association from causal evidence.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which headline is supported?

- A** The response rate rose to eighty percent this year.
- B** Reported employment among respondents rose from 40% to 50%; response coverage changed.
- C** The program caused a ten-percent improvement for every participant.
- D** Four hundred different residents gained jobs.

08

2. How should the employment-rate difference be stated?

- A** Ten percent relative and twenty-five percentage points
- B** Fifty percentage points
- C** A decrease of ten percentage points
- D** Ten percentage points, equivalent to a 25% relative increase from 40%

3. Which comparison describes survey response?

- A** Both cohorts had complete response
- B** Previous 80%; current 70%
- C** Previous 40%; current 50%
- D** Previous 70%; current 80%

4. What does the budget request still need?

- A** Only a larger attendance headline
- B** A claim that the requested amount is already appropriated
- C** An assumption that all nonrespondents found work
- D** A costed delivery and measurement plan with limits stated

Answers and explanations: [page 99](#).

Twenty workshops do not prove the outcome

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

cohort / percentage points / denominator / budget request / attribution / unique participant / Nonresponse bias / response rate / measurement plan / output

08

- 01 **Luis:** The workshop count tells me what we delivered. Before we ask for two hundred forty thousand next year, show me what we know about the people who attended.
- 02 **Faye:** The workshops are an ¹ _____, not the outcome itself. We also recorded four hundred attendances, but that includes repeat visits and should not be presented as four hundred different people.
- 03 **Luis:** Do we have a reliable count of distinct participants, or are those repeat visits still mixed together?
- 04 **Faye:** The supplied total is not a ² _____ count. I will not convert it into one. The follow-up survey provides a separate set of observations, with its own defined groups and response coverage.
- 05 **Luis:** Walk me through that measure. I want the numerator and denominator stated before we describe an improvement.
- 06 **Faye:** In the earlier ³ _____, eighty of two hundred respondents reported employment at ninety days. In the current cohort, one hundred five of two hundred ten respondents reported employment at the same follow-up point.
- 07 **Luis:** That gives forty percent and fifty percent among respondents. It does not tell us the employment rate among everyone invited.
- 08 **Faye:** Correct. The ⁴ _____ is respondents in each case. The note should keep that visible so readers do not assume complete follow-up or an outcome measured for every participant.
- 09 **Luis:** The draft says employment improved by ten percent. That wording could be read differently from the calculation we just made.
- 10 **Faye:** The absolute difference is ten ⁵ _____. Relative to the earlier forty-percent rate, that is a twenty-five-percent increase. I will use the first description and label the relative comparison if we include it.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 73.

- 11 **Luis:** How many people were invited to respond in each cohort? Different response patterns could affect the comparison.
- 12 **Faye:** The ⁶ _____ was two hundred out of two hundred fifty before, and two hundred ten out of three hundred now. That is eighty percent before and seventy percent now.
- 13 **Luis:** So the observed respondent rate improved while survey coverage fell. We should not hide either part of that picture.
- 14 **Faye:** Agreed. ⁷ _____ is a question to assess, not a result we can quantify from these figures alone. We need better information about missing responses and differences between the groups.
- 15 **Luis:** The draft says the workshops drove the increase. I see a before-and-after comparison, but no estimate of what would have happened without the program.
- 16 **Faye:** The evidence does not support that ⁸ _____. We have observed outcomes, but no design here establishing what would have happened without the program or accounting for other influences.
- 17 **Luis:** Then connect the request to a costed future plan as well. This year's actual spending was two hundred thousand, not two hundred forty thousand.
- 18 **Faye:** The ⁹ _____ is forty thousand higher, a twenty-percent increase. It still needs a delivery plan and explanation of the additional resources, not just a larger activity claim.
- 19 **Luis:** Keep the useful results, but make the limits readable. A careful explanation will help the reviewer understand what the evidence can and cannot support.
- 20 **Faye:** I will present the outputs, respondent outcomes, response rates, and a ¹⁰ _____ alongside the costed proposal. That gives the funding discussion a clear basis without claiming a causal success we have not established.

08

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 100

1. output | 2. unique participant | 3. cohort | 4. denominator | 5. percentage points | 6. response rate | 7. Nonresponse bias | 8. attribution | 9. budget request | 10. measurement plan

Compare a second program measure

F Say it

An earlier cohort has 30 employed respondents out of 100 respondents. A later cohort has 48 out of 120. Current spending is \$150,000 and the next-year request is \$180,000. No causal evaluation is supplied.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

30% / 40% / \$30,000 / 10 percentage points

Analyst: "The earlier respondent employment rate is ¹ _____."

Reviewer: "The later respondent employment rate is ² _____."

Analyst: "The increase in those rates is ³ _____."

Reviewer: "The requested funding increase is ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 100

1. 30% | 2. 40% | 3. 10 percentage points | 4. \$30,000

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10, stressing attendances, respondents, and percentage points.
2. Swap roles for turns 11-20 and read both response rates before discussing the funding request.
3. Complete the second program comparison and verify all four calculations against the supplied figures.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The amendment passed; the proposal did not

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Report the exact motion, voting basis, and outcome without confusing an amendment with the main decision.

Fictional committee rules: seven members; quorum four; five present throughout. Adoption requires more than half of votes cast, excluding abstentions. An amendment changes a proposed pilot from six months to three. Its vote is 3 yes, 1 no, 1 abstention. The subsequent main motion as amended receives 2 yes, 2 no, 1 abstention. These stipulated rules are not universal public-body law.

PEOPLE / Nora: Committee clerk | Felix: Committee chair

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

main motion as amended / amendment / abstention / majority / quorum / roll-call vote

- 01 **Nora:** Before you sign the minutes, we need to separate the two votes. The draft says the three-month pilot was approved, but that is not what the record shows.
- 02 **Felix:** We had a ¹ _____ throughout: five present against a requirement of four. The problem is the recorded outcome, not attendance.
- 03 **Nora:** Agreed. First, the committee voted on changing six months to three. Three voted yes, one no, and one abstained.
- 04 **Felix:** That ² _____ passed. But I then put the revised main motion to the committee, and the votes were different.
- 05 **Nora:** Two yes, two no, and one abstention. I have the roll-call record alongside the exact revised wording, so we can verify both separately.
- 06 **Felix:** Under our stated rule, the ³ _____ is based on votes cast, not all seven members or all five present. Four votes were cast on each question.
- 07 **Nora:** So the amendment's three to one is enough. The main motion's two to two is not more than half. The pilot was not approved.
- 08 **Felix:** Correct. Record the ⁴ _____ accurately, but do not turn it into a third no. We still need the record to distinguish a tie from a two-to-three defeat.
- 09 **Nora:** The member who moved the pilot has asked whether the approved change leaves us with a three-month pilot automatically.
- 10 **Felix:** No. The change became part of the ⁵ _____. Its later defeat means the committee did not authorize that revised proposal.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 76.

- 11 **Nora:** I will correct the summary to show amendment adopted, then main motion as amended lost. I will not collapse the votes into one result.
- 12 **Felix:** Please retain the exact wording too. A reader should be able to tell that three months replaced six months, not that a separate three-month extension was authorized.
- 13 **Nora:** The draft currently labels the result unanimous. That is wrong even for the amendment, because one member voted against it.
- 14 **Felix:** Remove that. The ⁶ _____ gives us the actual responses. There is no need for a broader label that contradicts them.
- 15 **Nora:** For the public summary, I can say the committee amended the proposal but did not approve the pilot. That is shorter without changing the result.
- 16 **Felix:** That works. Keep the detailed voting record in the minutes according to our process. Plain language should clarify the outcome, not erase the separate decisions.
- 17 **Nora:** I will also remove the instruction to schedule the pilot. It appears to have been generated from the incorrect approval summary.
- 18 **Felix:** Good catch. Notify the program team of the corrected result before it relies on that instruction. The defeated motion does not authorize implementation.
- 19 **Nora:** I will circulate the corrected draft through the minutes-approval process and retain the revision history, rather than silently replacing an approved record.
- 20 **Felix:** Thank you. The final check is straightforward: five present, four voting each time, amendment three to one, main motion two to two, and no pilot approval.

09

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 101

1. quorum | 2. amendment | 3. majority | 4. abstention | 5. main motion as amended | 6. roll-call vote

Use the stated voting basis

F Say it in a new situation

A separate fictional board has six members present and a quorum requirement of five. A motion receives 3 yes, 2 no, and 1 abstention. Its rule requires more than half of votes cast, excluding abstentions.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

5 / 3 / adopted / five

09

Clerk: The quorum requirement is ¹ _____ members.

Chair: The number of votes actually cast is ² _____.

Clerk: The number of affirmative votes is ³ _____.

Chair: Under this rule, the motion is ⁴ _____.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 101

1. five | 2. 5 | 3. 3 | 4. adopted

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

Unspent does not mean uncommitted

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Reconcile available budget, outstanding commitments, and a final invoice without counting reserved funds twice.

Fictional budget report: appropriation \$120,000; expenditure \$62,000; separate outstanding encumbrances \$38,000. An included order with \$15,000 reserved is fully completed for a final accepted \$12,000 invoice. The unused \$3,000 is formally released and the order closed. No other changes apply. These figures use the stipulated reporting basis, not a universal accounting treatment.

PEOPLE / Ravi: Department manager | Elena: Budget analyst

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

10

WORD + PHRASE BANK

unencumbered balance / budgetary basis / release of encumbrance / encumbrances / appropriation / final invoice

- 01 **Ravi:** The report shows sixty-two thousand spent from a hundred twenty thousand. I was about to tell the team we have fifty-eight thousand left for new orders.
- 02 **Elena:** That ignores the ¹ _____. Thirty-eight thousand is reserved for orders, leaving twenty thousand available before the final invoice.
- 03 **Ravi:** Let me put the authorized budget, expenditure, and outstanding commitments side by side. We need all three for this check.
- 04 **Elena:** Yes. From the ² _____ of a hundred twenty thousand, subtract sixty-two thousand spent and thirty-eight thousand reserved, once each.
- 05 **Ravi:** One order has finished. We reserved fifteen thousand; the accepted final invoice is twelve. Does that free the entire fifteen?
- 06 **Elena:** No. The ³ _____ uses twelve thousand of that reservation. Only the remaining three thousand becomes available when the unused amount is formally released.
- 07 **Ravi:** The whole order is complete, with no remaining delivery or charge. We have that confirmation in the record.
- 08 **Elena:** That confirmation matters. Under the stated ⁴ _____, expenditure rises to seventy-four thousand and outstanding encumbrances fall to twenty-three thousand.
- 09 **Ravi:** That is sixty-two plus twelve, and thirty-eight less fifteen. Then a hundred twenty less seventy-four less twenty-three gives twenty-three thousand available.
- 10 **Elena:** Exactly. The ⁵ _____ increases by three thousand, not fifteen. The invoice replaced part of an existing reservation rather than creating a completely separate commitment.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 79.

- 11 **Ravi:** Someone has already entered the twelve-thousand invoice in a local worksheet while leaving all thirty-eight thousand encumbered. That would understate what remains.
- 12 **Elena:** It would count the same twelve thousand as both expenditure and an outstanding reservation. Reconcile the worksheet to the controlled report and the completed order record.
- 13 **Ravi:** I will also avoid calling the released three thousand a cash refund. No supplier has paid anything back in these facts.
- 14 **Elena:** Right. A ⁶ _____ changes budget availability. A cash receipt would need its own transaction and evidence.
- 15 **Ravi:** Could we transfer the twenty-three thousand to a different program because the report now shows it available?
- 16 **Elena:** Not from this calculation alone. Available within this budget does not establish transfer authority. Any transfer or new commitment still follows the applicable budget and purchasing controls.
- 17 **Ravi:** Then I will show the revised balance and separately identify the proposed use. The arithmetic should not make the approval decision for us.
- 18 **Elena:** That is the right separation. Keep the appropriation, expenditure, remaining commitments, and calculation date visible so another reviewer can reproduce the result.
- 19 **Ravi:** My revised update is seventy-four thousand spent, twenty-three thousand still reserved, twenty-three thousand available, with the completed order formally closed.
- 20 **Elena:** Those figures reconcile to a hundred twenty thousand. Attach the final-invoice and release references so the next report does not restore the old reservation by mistake.

10

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 102

1. encumbrances | 2. appropriation | 3. final invoice | 4. budgetary basis | 5. unencumbered balance | 6. release of encumbrance

Close a fully completed order

F Say it in a new situation

Fictional report: \$90,000 appropriation, \$40,000 expenditure, and \$35,000 separate outstanding encumbrances. An included \$10,000 order is completed for a final \$8,000. Its unused \$2,000 is released and the order closed; no other changes occur.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

15 / 48 / 17 / 25

10

Manager: Before the final invoice, available budget is \$¹ _____ thousand.

Analyst: Revised expenditure is \$² _____ thousand.

Manager: Remaining encumbrances are \$³ _____ thousand.

Analyst: Revised available budget is \$⁴ _____ thousand.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 102

1. 15 | 2. 48 | 3. 25 | 4. 17

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

A notice residents can act on

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Replace administrative jargon with clear instructions while preserving the exact document choices, deadline, and submission route.

Fictional allotment-renewal notice R18: the signed renewal form must arrive with ONE of three listed address documents: a current utility bill, tenancy agreement, or council letter. Both items must be received by 24 October at 17:00 local time, through the renewal portal or Service Desk. A postmark is insufficient. A reference number confirms receipt only. The proposed shorter notice wrongly says send all documents by 24 October.

PEOPLE / Mae: Public-service editor | Omar: Renewals officer

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

received by / one of / receipt confirmation / active voice / submission routes / supporting evidence

11

- 01 **Mae:** The shorter version is easier to read, but it changes what residents have to do. Send all documents is not equivalent to one document from this list.
- 02 **Omar:** The ¹ _____ is a single accepted address document. We also need the signed renewal form, so there are two required items in the submission.
- 03 **Mae:** Then let us separate the instruction from the choices. Submit your signed renewal form and one of the following address documents. The list can sit immediately below.
- 04 **Omar:** Keep ² _____ prominent. A utility bill, tenancy agreement, or council letter is acceptable under the stated process. We should not add documents that the policy does not list.
- 05 **Mae:** The deadline sentence also lost the time. Someone reading by twenty-four October might reasonably assume they have until midnight.
- 06 **Omar:** Write ³ _____ twenty-four October at 17:00 local time. Both the form and the selected document must arrive by that cutoff.
- 07 **Mae:** I will put that near the action, not in a footer. Do we still accept both the renewal portal and the Service Desk?
- 08 **Omar:** Yes. Those are the two stated ⁴ _____. Do not replace them with online only just because the portal link is convenient to print.
- 09 **Mae:** I also want the sentence to name who receives the material. Your renewal form must be submitted hides the action and makes the next step less immediate.
- 10 **Omar:** Use ⁵ _____. We can speak directly to the resident while keeping the required documents and deadline exact.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 82.

- 11 **Mae:** Below the portal link, the draft says a reference number means renewal approved. That is not supported by the intake process.
- 12 **Omar:** Change it to ⁶ _____. The team still checks the application. The reference is useful for an inquiry, but it is not an approval notice.
- 13 **Mae:** Could we test the new version with the service team by asking them to identify the two required items, deadline, and available routes?
- 14 **Omar:** Yes. Give them the notice rather than explaining it first. If they select all three address documents, the wording or layout still needs work.
- 15 **Mae:** I will also ask them whether a twenty-fourth-of-October postmark is enough. The correct answer under these instructions is no; arrival is what matters.
- 16 **Omar:** And ask what the reference number establishes. Those checks cover the errors residents would actually encounter, rather than whether colleagues merely like the shorter text.
- 17 **Mae:** The revised version will use a short document list, a separate deadline line, and labeled submission routes. The contact details will remain with the notice.
- 18 **Omar:** Keep R18 visible too. Staff need to identify the version a resident received if an older copy is still circulating.
- 19 **Mae:** I will send the revised wording for process-owner approval before publication. Clearer wording is still a change that must match the current requirements.
- 20 **Omar:** Agreed. The final check is signed form plus one accepted address document, received by the exact cutoff, through either stated route, with receipt distinguished from approval.

11

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 103

1. supporting evidence | 2. one of | 3. received by | 4. submission routes | 5. active voice | 6. receipt confirmation

Check a second notice

F Say it in a new situation

Fictional notice S20 requires a signed application plus ONE of a current lease or accepted council letter. Both must be received by 6 November at 16:00 local time. The reference confirms receipt, not approval.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

receipt / one / application / 16:00

Editor: The applicant chooses ¹ _____ of the two address documents.

Officer: The chosen document accompanies the signed ² _____.

Editor: Both items must arrive by ³ _____ local time on 6 November.

Officer: The reference number confirms ⁴ _____.

11

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 103

1. one | 2. application | 3. 16:00 | 4. receipt

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.

2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.

3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

01 Briefing and language checks

Policy Implementation and Program Rules

A Briefing checks / page 4

1. Which document explains the current requirements?

C. Guidance G4

G4 is identified as the published guidance explaining the current program requirements.

2. What does P2 propose?

B. Reducing the residence period to six months

P2 proposes a six-month residence period, but adoption and an effective date are absent.

3. What can Theo accurately say about nine months?

D. It is below the current 12-month residence condition.

Nine months is shorter than the current residence condition, but the desk conversation is not a formal determination.

D Language checks / page 9

1. Which explanation is accurate?

B. P2 proposes six months; G4 still describes the current twelve-month condition.

The accurate explanation preserves both document status and the current versus proposed periods.

2. Which response avoids an unauthorized decision?

A. Nine months is below the current condition; I can explain the formal review process.

The response explains the stated condition without issuing a decision or inventing authority.

3. What should Theo check before describing a change as operative?

A. Its adoption, applicable terms, and effective date

Publication, a website link, or the end of consultation alone does not make the proposal operative; adoption and applicability must be checked.

4. Which statement keeps the processes distinct?

C. Commenting on P2 does not itself submit an application for the grant.

Consultation input and a program application have different purposes and must not be conflated.

01 Conversation answers

Policy Implementation and Program Rules

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 10-11

1. proposal. Turn 2. Proposal identifies P2 as a suggested change, not an adopted replacement for the current program condition.

2. current guidance. Turn 4. Current guidance is G4, the identified explanation of the presently applicable program requirements.

3. effective date. Turn 6. Effective date identifies when a measure applies; P2 has no such date because the proposed change is not adopted.

4. residence requirement. Turn 8. Residence requirement is the stated twelve-month condition; nine months is below it without resolving every other eligibility question.

5. eligibility determination. Turn 10. Eligibility determination is an authorized qualification decision, which this information conversation does not issue.

6. eligibility criterion. Turn 12. Eligibility criterion is one condition within the program's test; meeting it alone would not establish entitlement to an award.

7. transition provision. Turn 14. Transition provision governs movement between arrangements; future application treatment cannot be invented before the adopted terms are known.

8. public comment. Turn 16. Public comment contributes to consultation on the proposal; it is separate from applying for an individual program benefit.

9. adoption. Turn 18. Adoption is formal acceptance through the applicable process; publication of a proposal alone does not establish it.

10. application intake. Turn 20. Application intake is the process of receiving a program application, distinct from giving information or collecting consultation comments.

F Transfer conversation

Page 12

1. H3

Officer: "The current guidance is H3."

H3 is explicitly identified as the document stating the presently applicable condition.

2. eight months

Resident: "The current residence condition is eight months."

Eight months is current; four months belongs to the unadopted proposal.

3. not adopted

Officer: "The proposal's status is not adopted."

Q1 has not been adopted, so its proposed period cannot replace the current condition.

4. not been made

Resident: "A formal application decision has not been made."

The record expressly says that no formal determination has been issued.

02 Briefing and language checks

Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

A Briefing checks / page 13

1. Who should be called next under the announced process?

C. The next registered speaker who has not had an initial turn

Five registered speakers remain unheard, and the announced process gives initial turns before second turns.

2. What is the written-submission deadline?

A. Friday at 17:00 local time

The brief expressly states the Friday local-time deadline for written input.

3. What is this meeting's purpose?

C. To gather input, not decide the proposal by a public vote

The stated consultation purpose is collecting input rather than holding an up-or-down vote.

D Language checks / page 18

1. Which intervention best follows the process?

A. Thank you; we will hear the remaining initial speakers before returning to second turns.

The intervention applies the announced priority without favoring a viewpoint or canceling unheard contributions.

2. Which record entry is appropriately attributed?

B. A speaker reported concerns about evening access.

Attribution preserves the reported concern without converting one contribution into verified or universal evidence.

3. How should an access request be handled?

C. Through the announced accessibility arrangements

Consistent treatment includes the stated access process; identical format, counting the request as a contribution, or delaying support may prevent participation.

4. Which explanation correctly describes the meeting?

D. It gathers input for the designated decision process.

The consultation collects input but does not transfer decision authority to applause or individual submissions.

02 Conversation answers

Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 19-20

1. initial turn. Turn 2. Initial turn is the first speaking opportunity, which the announced process gives priority over repeat contributions.

2. procedural reminder. Turn 4. Procedural reminder restates the announced turn-taking rule without criticizing the substance or intensity of a contribution.

3. viewpoint neutrality. Turn 6. Viewpoint neutrality applies the participation process consistently to supporters and opponents rather than favoring a position.

4. second turn. Turn 8. Second turn is a later opportunity after initial contributions; it should not be guaranteed before the announced priority is met.

5. submission deadline. Turn 10. Submission deadline is Friday at 17:00 local time, the announced cutoff for written input in this fictional meeting.

6. consultation. Turn 12. Consultation gathers input for a decision process; applause and speaker counts are not a binding public ballot here.

7. attribution. Turn 14. Attribution identifies the speaker as the source, avoiding conversion of an individual report into a verified community-wide finding.

8. accessibility arrangement. Turn 16. Accessibility arrangement supports participation through the stated process; it should not be dismissed as a viewpoint-based request for influence.

9. meeting record. Turn 18. Meeting record preserves the contributions and procedural actions so the later decision process has an accurate account.

10. decision authority. Turn 20. Decision authority identifies the body empowered to decide, separating receipt of public input from approval of the proposal.

F Transfer conversation

Page 21

1. two minutes

Chair: "The initial speaking allocation is two minutes."

The announced process assigns two minutes to each initial contribution.

2. three

Clerk: "The number of registered people still unheard is three."

Three people remain entitled to the next initial turns under the stated process.

3. Wednesday at 12:00 local time

Chair: "Written input closes Wednesday at 12:00 local time."

The deadline includes the day, time, and local-time reference from the announcement.

4. consultation

Clerk: "The session is a consultation."

The session gathers input rather than determining the outcome through a public ballot.

03 Briefing and language checks

Procurement and Vendor Selection

03

A Briefing checks / page 22

1. What are the recorded totals?

A. A has 86 and B has 82.

Adding the three recorded weighted scores produces totals of eighty-six and eighty-two.

2. What is A's price premium?

B. \$10,000

A's price of one hundred twenty thousand exceeds B's one hundred ten thousand by ten thousand.

3. Which consideration is not a published criterion?

A. The vendor's local address

The brief lists three published factors and expressly excludes local address as a criterion.

D Language checks / page 27

1. Which evaluation note is strongest?

C. Link A's scored strengths to proposal evidence and explain the \$10,000 premium.

The strongest note connects the comparative benefits, evidence, and cost under the published method.

2. What should happen to the existing weighted scores?

D. Check their arithmetic without applying the weights again.

The scores are already weighted, so a second weighting would distort the recorded method.

3. Which statement preserves authority?

A. The evaluation recommends A; the award decision remains pending.

The brief gives the evaluation team a recommendation role while award authorization remains outstanding.

4. Which challenge is appropriate?

B. Which published factor and submitted evidence support that claimed strength?

The challenge tests the rationale within the stated rules instead of changing them to fit a desired result.

03 Conversation answers

Procurement and Vendor Selection

03

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 28-29

- 1. scoring matrix.** Turn 2. Scoring matrix records each proposal's assessment against the stated factors, allowing the totals and differences to be checked.
- 2. weighted score.** Turn 4. Weighted score already incorporates the specified importance; applying the weights again would change the method and distort the totals.
- 3. price premium.** Turn 6. Price premium is the ten-thousand-dollar difference between the two quoted prices, which the trade-off reasoning must address.
- 4. evaluation narrative.** Turn 8. Evaluation narrative supplies the reasons and evidence behind scores rather than relying on a numerical total alone.
- 5. evaluation factor.** Turn 10. Evaluation factor is a published assessment dimension; local address is not one of the stated criteria here.
- 6. trade-off.** Turn 12. Trade-off compares the assessed benefits with the additional cost under the permitted method, retaining both favorable and unfavorable evidence.
- 7. Best value.** Turn 14. Best value is the most advantageous result under the applicable selection method, not a universal consequence of a score or price.
- 8. conflict of interest.** Turn 16. Conflict of interest concerns an interest that could influence official judgment; it requires the applicable disclosure and review process.
- 9. award authority.** Turn 18. Award authority is the empowered decision-maker; the evaluation team's recommendation does not itself authorize or execute an award.
- 10. audit trail.** Turn 20. Audit trail links the conclusion to the criteria, evidence, arithmetic, and approvals, allowing later review of the decision.

F Transfer conversation

Page 30

1. 85

Evaluator: "C's total weighted score is 85."

Forty-two plus twenty-six plus seventeen equals eighty-five without applying weights again.

2. 84

Officer: "D's total weighted score is 84."

Forty plus twenty-five plus nineteen equals eighty-four under the supplied scoring record.

3. \$5,000

Evaluator: "C's price premium is \$5,000."

Seventy-five thousand minus seventy thousand gives a five-thousand-dollar premium.

4. approval pending

Officer: "The award status is approval pending."

The stated approval has not occurred, so a score comparison does not itself award the contract.

04 Briefing and language checks

Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

04

A Briefing checks / page 31

1. What total do the assembled supporting records substantiate?

B. \$47,000

Twenty-nine thousand plus twelve thousand plus six thousand equals forty-seven thousand.

2. Where is the evidence gap?

A. A \$1,000 personnel item

The personnel report exceeds the assembled personnel support by one thousand dollars.

3. What conclusion is not established by the difference alone?

B. Fraud or cost allowability

The discrepancy identifies missing support but does not determine intent or whether the cost is allowable.

D Language checks / page 36

1. Which reconciliation statement is correct?

D. Reported expenditure is \$48,000; assembled support is \$47,000, with \$1,000 unresolved in personnel.

The category sum is correct, but one personnel item lacks its requested supporting record.

2. What should Owen do first with the specific gap?

A. Trace the personnel item and seek the missing support.

Tracing the identified item addresses the actual evidence gap without inventing treatment or intent.

3. Which statement about allowability is sound?

B. It requires review under the applicable rules and award terms.

Evidence and correct arithmetic matter, but cost allowability also depends on the governing requirements.

4. What should a correction preserve?

C. A traceable record of the original figure, reason, approval, and revised treatment

A documented correction lets reviewers understand what changed, why, and under whose authority.

04 Conversation answers

Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 37-38

1. supporting schedule. Turn 2. Supporting schedule breaks down the total into categories so the reported amount can be compared with the corresponding evidence.

2. source documentation. Turn 4. Source documentation substantiates the transaction; the requested record for one personnel item is absent from the assembled evidence.

3. reconciliation. Turn 6. Reconciliation compares the report with supporting records and identifies the precise difference rather than concealing it in the total.

4. budget category. Turn 8. Budget category should reflect the transaction's proper classification, not a convenient place to hide an unsupported amount.

5. unsupported item. Turn 10. Unsupported item accurately describes the missing required evidence without asserting fraudulent intent or a final cost decision.

6. Allowable cost. Turn 12. Allowable cost depends on the governing rules and award terms; finding a record alone does not decide that status.

7. reporting period. Turn 14. Reporting period defines the interval covered by the report; mismatched periods can create misleading differences in a reconciliation.

8. certification. Turn 16. Certification is an authorized attestation; an unresolved required evidence gap must not be hidden when completeness is attested.

9. corrected report. Turn 18. Corrected report records an authorized revision; the original amount, reason, and approval should remain traceable.

10. variance. Turn 20. Variance is the one-thousand-dollar difference between reported and supported figures; it remains visible until an evidenced treatment resolves it.

F Transfer conversation

Page 39

1. \$28,000

Officer: "The reported total is \$28,000."

Eighteen thousand plus seven thousand plus three thousand equals twenty-eight thousand.

2. \$27,500

Coordinator: "The supported total is \$27,500."

Eighteen thousand plus six thousand five hundred plus three thousand equals twenty-seven thousand five hundred.

3. \$500

Officer: "The unresolved difference is \$500."

The reported total exceeds the assembled support by five hundred dollars.

4. materials

Coordinator: "The affected category is materials."

Personnel and travel match their support; the five-hundred-dollar difference is in materials.

04

05 Briefing and language checks

Interagency Coordination

A Briefing checks / page 40

1. Who owns the resident update?

B. Jon at 15:00 local time

Jon explicitly accepts responsibility for the resident update at the stated local time.

2. What will Transit provide by 14:30?

D. An availability status to Jon

Aisha commits to sending a status on availability, not approving eligibility or guaranteeing a booking.

3. What remains unconfirmed?

A. Eligibility and the transport booking

The offices have assigned communication tasks, but neither the eligibility decision nor booking is confirmed.

D Language checks / page 45

1. Which handoff is complete?

C. Aisha sends the availability status by 14:30; Jon confirms receipt and updates the resident at 15:00.

The complete handoff names actions, recipients, timing, and confirmation without claiming service approval.

2. Which statement preserves the agencies' roles?

D. Community reviews eligibility; Transit checks availability.

The brief assigns these distinct responsibilities and leaves both substantive outcomes open.

3. Which information belongs in the authorized initial exchange?

B. Request reference, pickup zone, and requested window

The defined initial task needs the specified limited information, not unnecessary sensitive records.

4. What should happen if availability remains unknown at 14:30?

D. Aisha sends that status and the open question so Jon can give the promised update.

A progress update remains useful and due even when the underlying resource decision is incomplete.

05 Conversation answers

Interagency Coordination

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 46-47

1. lead contact. Turn 2. Lead contact identifies who coordinates resident communication, resolving the earlier ambiguity between offices.

2. action owner. Turn 4. Action owner assigns Aisha the Transit status task, distinct from Jon's resident update.

3. availability check. Turn 6. Availability check assesses resources; it does not automatically confirm a reservation or a completed journey.

4. eligibility review. Turn 8. Eligibility review remains Community's task; coordination assignments do not decide whether the resident qualifies.

5. request reference. Turn 10. Request reference links the offices' records to Q41 without repeating unnecessary personal information.

6. secure channel. Turn 12. Secure channel is the approved route for this authorized exchange, preserving safeguards while the two offices coordinate.

7. acknowledgment of receipt. Turn 14. Acknowledgment of receipt confirms arrival, not task ownership; acceptance must also be explicit.

8. joint status. Turn 16. Joint status combines both offices' progress and open questions without implying completed decisions.

9. escalation contact. Turn 18. Escalation contact provides a named route for unresolved coordination issues, preventing another round of unowned messages.

10. closed-loop handoff. Turn 20. Closed-loop handoff confirms receipt, ownership, and next actions instead of relying on message delivery alone.

F Transfer conversation

Page 48

1. Bea

Coordinator: "The internal status owner is Bea."

Bea is assigned to send Mobility's availability status to Eli.

2. 10:00

Officer: "The internal update deadline is 10:00."

This deadline precedes the resident update and gives Eli the information needed for that contact.

3. Eli

Coordinator: "The resident-contact owner is Eli."

Eli owns communication with the resident, distinct from Bea's availability task.

4. 10:30 local time

Officer: "The resident update is at 10:30 local time."

The supplied resident-contact commitment includes the exact time and its local-time reference.

05

06 Briefing and language checks

Constituent Services and Escalation

A Briefing checks / page 49

1. Which office receives the site plan under this process?

D. Public Works Permit Intake

The brief expressly assigns receipt and routing of sidewalk-use applications to Public Works Permit Intake.

2. What is Ben's Wednesday 10:00 commitment?

A. A follow-up call about the referral

Ben promises a status call, not an application outcome or completion of every review step.

3. How should the redirection complaint be recorded?

D. Separately from the permit application

The complaint concerns service handling and should not be confused with the separate permit decision.

D Language checks / page 54

1. Which explanation gives a useful referral?

B. Licensing handles registration; Public Works Permit Intake receives the sidewalk application and site plan.

The explanation names the responsible function and required intake item without promising permission.

2. Which follow-up statement is accurate?

C. I will call Wednesday at 10:00 local time with the referral status.

Ben can promise a status contact, while acceptance and substantive decisions remain unconfirmed.

3. What preserves case continuity?

A. An authorized relevant summary and confirmation of the receiving contact

A relevant, authorized handoff reduces repetition while retaining ownership and appropriate information limits.

4. How should the complaint affect the permit decision?

A. It should be handled separately, without pre-deciding the permit.

The service complaint concerns handling, not whether the proposed sidewalk use meets permit requirements.

06 Conversation answers

Constituent Services and Escalation

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 55-56

- 1. service remit.** Turn 2. Service remit identifies what each office handles, explaining the referral rather than merely redirecting the resident.
- 2. sidewalk-use permit.** Turn 4. Sidewalk-use permit concerns this town's public-space permission, which business registration alone does not provide.
- 3. site plan.** Turn 6. Site plan shows the proposed location and layout for the permit process, rather than proving that the proposal is already approved.
- 4. case summary.** Turn 8. Case summary preserves the issue and contact history, reducing unnecessary repetition for the resident.
- 5. Referral acceptance.** Turn 10. Referral acceptance confirms that the receiving office has taken the matter; a sent message alone does not establish this.
- 6. follow-up call.** Turn 12. Follow-up call is a timed status contact within Ben's control, not a deadline for granting the permit.
- 7. decision deadline.** Turn 14. Decision deadline is a separate requirement of the permit process; Ben's call commitment does not create or replace it.
- 8. service complaint.** Turn 16. Service complaint addresses the handling experience; it should not be treated as an application, an approval, or a reason for refusal.
- 9. case continuity.** Turn 18. Case continuity preserves relevant history while keeping the complaint and permit application distinguishable.
- 10. closure reason.** Turn 20. Closure reason explains the actual outcome; an unaccepted referral does not establish resolution.

F Transfer conversation

Page 57

1. Road Use Intake

Resident: "The office receiving the banner plan is Road Use Intake."

The local process assigns banner-plan receipt to Road Use Intake, not Events Registration.

2. Hana

Officer: "The promised follow-up owner is Hana."

Hana is the named officer who commits to the referral-status call.

3. Thursday at 14:00 local time

Resident: "The call is scheduled for Thursday at 14:00 local time."

The stated contact includes the day, time, and local-time reference.

4. referral status

Officer: "The call concerns referral status."

The promise is to report the referral position, not to guarantee a permit decision.

06

07 Briefing and language checks

Transparency, Records, and Ethics

A Briefing checks / page 58

1. What has been established?

D. Eight responsive contract files have been located.

The search located eight responsive files, but the release review has not reached a decision.

2. What needs correction?

A. The promise of automatic full release

The acknowledgment overpromises disclosure before the required review of potentially protected information.

3. What follows from personal details appearing in two files?

C. Those details require review; full-file withholding is not automatic.

Potentially protected details call for the applicable review, including consideration of releasable portions.

D Language checks / page 63

1. Which update is accurate?

A. Eight responsive files were located; disclosure review remains underway.

The update reports the completed search step while preserving the unresolved disclosure decision.

2. How should the earlier acknowledgment be handled?

A. Correct the automatic-release promise and explain the actual review status.

The requester needs an explicit correction and actual status; silence, premature withholding, or an unexplained replacement leaves the error unresolved.

3. What is the right response to a proposed full-file withholding?

A. Ask for the applicable basis and assess whether releasable portions can be separated.

The responsible assessment must address the basis and possible partial disclosure, not merely the presence of sensitive material.

4. What should remain intact?

B. The source records under applicable preservation requirements

Release preparation does not authorize alteration or destruction of the underlying agency records.

07 Conversation answers

Transparency, Records, and Ethics

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 64-65

1. responsive records. Turn 2. Responsive records match the request; locating them does not clear every part for disclosure.

2. request scope. Turn 4. Request scope defines the contracts, attachments, and date range, keeping the search boundaries explicit.

3. exemption. Turn 6. Exemption requires assessment against the information and legal standard, not automatic full-file withholding.

4. segregable information. Turn 8. Segregable information can be separated from protected material, allowing responsible reviewers to assess release of nonprotected portions.

5. records preservation. Turn 10. Records preservation keeps sources intact; disclosure preparation does not authorize changes to the originals.

6. redaction. Turn 12. Redaction removes or masks protected information in the release version while leaving the original record preserved.

7. acknowledgment. Turn 14. Acknowledgment confirms receipt; its mistaken release promise needs correction, not treatment as a disclosure decision.

8. review status. Turn 16. Review status describes the current assessment and pending steps; it should not be replaced by an unsupported release deadline.

9. partial release. Turn 18. Partial release discloses releasable portions while applying any justified withholding under the completed assessment.

10. administrative appeal. Turn 20. Administrative appeal is the agency-level review route for an initial decision, distinct from the present progress update.

F Transfer conversation

Page 66

1. C44

Liaison: "The request reference is C44."

C44 is the tracking reference supplied for this separate records request.

2. six responsive files

Officer: "The search found six responsive files."

Six files match the stated request scope, but responsiveness does not establish disclosure clearance.

3. April

Liaison: "The requested month is April."

April is the time boundary stated for the final inspection reports.

4. not yet made

Officer: "The disclosure decision is not yet made."

The record explicitly leaves release and withholding undecided pending the responsible review.

08 Briefing and language checks

Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

A Briefing checks / page 67

1. What do the 400 attendances count?

A. Visits, including repeat visits

The attendance count includes repeat visits and therefore is not a unique-person or employment count.

2. What is the current respondent employment rate?

B. 50%

One hundred five employed respondents divided by two hundred ten respondents equals fifty percent.

3. How much does the requested budget exceed current spending?

B. \$40,000, or 20%

The difference is forty thousand, and forty thousand divided by two hundred thousand is twenty percent.

D Language checks / page 72

1. Which headline is supported?

B. Reported employment among respondents rose from 40% to 50%; response coverage changed.

The supported headline keeps the respondent denominator and acknowledges the changed response coverage.

2. How should the employment-rate difference be stated?

D. Ten percentage points, equivalent to a 25% relative increase from 40%

Fifty minus forty equals ten points; ten divided by the forty-percent baseline equals twenty-five percent.

3. Which comparison describes survey response?

B. Previous 80%; current 70%

Two hundred of two hundred fifty is eighty percent; two hundred ten of three hundred is seventy percent.

4. What does the budget request still need?

D. A costed delivery and measurement plan with limits stated

Past activity counts and limited outcome observations do not alone establish the future plan or its funding authorization.

08 Conversation answers

Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 73-74

- 1. output.** Turn 2. Output is a direct count of services delivered; twenty workshops describes activity rather than a demonstrated change in residents' circumstances.
- 2. unique participant.** Turn 4. Unique participant counts each person once; the four-hundred attendance total includes repeat visits and cannot supply that count.
- 3. cohort.** Turn 6. Cohort identifies the group followed in a particular period, making clear that the two survey results concern different groups.
- 4. denominator.** Turn 8. Denominator is the respondent count used in the employment calculation, not the larger invited population or the attendance total.
- 5. percentage points.** Turn 10. Percentage points expresses fifty percent minus forty percent; it differs from the relative increase based on the starting rate.
- 6. response rate.** Turn 12. Response rate divides responses by invitations: 200/250 is 80%, while 210/300 is 70%.
- 7. Nonresponse bias.** Turn 14. Nonresponse bias may arise if respondents differ systematically from those not responding; the changed coverage warrants examination rather than assumed representativeness.
- 8. attribution.** Turn 16. Attribution assigns the observed change to the program; these cohort observations alone do not establish causation.
- 9. budget request.** Turn 18. Budget request proposes future funding; here it exceeds current spending by forty thousand dollars, or twenty percent.
- 10. measurement plan.** Turn 20. Measurement plan specifies future evidence collection and interpretation, addressing gaps rather than overstating the current findings.

F Transfer conversation

Page 75

1. 30%

Analyst: "The earlier respondent employment rate is 30%."

Thirty divided by one hundred equals thirty percent among respondents.

2. 40%

Reviewer: "The later respondent employment rate is 40%."

Forty-eight divided by one hundred twenty equals forty percent among respondents.

3. 10 percentage points

Analyst: "The increase in those rates is 10 percentage points."

Forty percent minus thirty percent is ten percentage points, not a ten-percent relative change.

4. \$30,000

Reviewer: "The requested funding increase is \$30,000."

One hundred eighty thousand minus one hundred fifty thousand equals thirty thousand dollars.

09 Conversation answers

The amendment passed; the proposal did not

E Extended conversation

Pages 76-77

1. quorum. Turn 2. Quorum is the minimum presence required to conduct the business; five members were present, exceeding the fictional committee's requirement of four.

2. amendment. Turn 4. The amendment changed the proposed pilot's duration from six months to three; adopting that change did not adopt the pilot itself.

3. majority. Turn 6. A majority here means more than half of votes actually cast; the fictional rule excludes abstentions, so three affirmative votes are needed when four votes are cast.

4. abstention. Turn 8. An abstention records that a present member did not vote; under these supplied rules it is excluded from votes cast rather than counted as a no.

5. main motion as amended. Turn 10. The main motion as amended is the substantive proposal with the adopted change incorporated; it still needed its own successful vote, which it did not receive.

6. roll-call vote. Turn 14. A roll-call vote identifies individual members' recorded responses; it supports verification of the totals and preserves the distinction among yes, no, and abstention.

F Transfer exchange

Page 78

1. five

Clerk: The quorum requirement is five members.

The supplied requirement is five, which is met by the six members present.

2. 5

Chair: The number of votes actually cast is 5.

Three yes plus two no makes five votes; the abstention is excluded under this stated rule.

3. 3

Clerk: The number of affirmative votes is 3.

The motion received three yes votes, which is more than half of the five votes cast.

4. adopted

Chair: Under this rule, the motion is adopted.

Three of five votes is a majority, so the stated adoption requirement is satisfied.

09

Background reading: [Official Robert's Rules: majority, abstentions, and amendments; check governing law first](#). The conversation is an original fictional teaching case.

10 Conversation answers

Unspent does not mean uncommitted

E Extended conversation

Pages 79-80

1. encumbrances. Turn 2. Encumbrances reserve budget for outstanding commitments under this report's basis; the 38,000 is not included in the 62,000 expenditure and is not freely available for new orders.

2. appropriation. Turn 4. The appropriation is the stipulated 120,000 spending authority in this example; it is distinct from both money already spent and the department's bank balance.

3. final invoice. Turn 6. The final invoice is the accepted 12,000 charge for the completed order; recording it uses twelve thousand of the amount previously reserved.

4. budgetary basis. Turn 8. The budgetary basis defines how this report treats expenditure and outstanding reservations; using the same stipulated basis prevents double counting or mixing it with cash or financial-statement measures.

5. unencumbered balance. Turn 10. The unencumbered balance is the amount available after recorded expenditure and remaining reservations on this report's basis: 120,000 minus 74,000 minus 23,000 equals 23,000.

6. release of encumbrance. Turn 14. A release of encumbrance removes budget reserved for an obligation no longer outstanding; it does not itself describe a cash receipt or supplier refund.

F Transfer exchange

Page 81

1. 15

Manager: Before the final invoice, available budget is \$15 thousand.

Ninety minus forty minus thirty-five equals fifteen thousand available before the order closes.

2. 48

Analyst: Revised expenditure is \$48 thousand.

The final eight-thousand invoice increases recorded expenditure from forty to forty-eight thousand.

3. 25

Manager: Remaining encumbrances are \$25 thousand.

The entire ten-thousand reservation for the completed order leaves the outstanding thirty-five-thousand balance.

4. 17

Analyst: Revised available budget is \$17 thousand.

Ninety minus forty-eight minus twenty-five equals seventeen thousand, a two-thousand increase from the released unused reservation.

10

Background reading: [Government Finance Officers Association: budget monitoring and outstanding commitments](#). The conversation is an original fictional teaching case.

11 Conversation answers

A notice residents can act on

E Extended conversation

Pages 82-83

1. supporting evidence. Turn 2. Supporting evidence is one of the three accepted address documents in this fictional process; the notice must not turn an alternative list into a requirement to supply all three.

2. one of. Turn 4. One of expresses an alternative choice among the listed documents; it prevents the three acceptable options from becoming three cumulative requirements.

3. received by. Turn 6. Received by makes arrival the deadline condition; merely sending or postmarking the submission before the cutoff does not satisfy this fictional process.

4. submission routes. Turn 8. Submission routes identify the authorized ways to provide the material: the renewal portal or Service Desk; simplifying the notice must not remove an available route.

5. active voice. Turn 10. Active voice makes the actor and action explicit, as in Submit your signed renewal form; it improves clarity without altering what the process requires.

6. receipt confirmation. Turn 12. Receipt confirmation shows that a submission arrived and provides its reference; it does not establish completeness, eligibility, or approval of the renewal.

F Transfer exchange

Page 84

1. one

Editor: The applicant chooses one of the two address documents.

The notice gives two alternative address documents, not a requirement to submit both.

2. application

Officer: The chosen document accompanies the signed application.

The application is required in addition to one accepted address document.

3. 16:00

Editor: Both items must arrive by 16:00 local time on 6 November.

The exact supplied cutoff is 16:00, not midnight or merely a posting date.

4. receipt

Officer: The reference number confirms receipt.

The scenario explicitly limits the reference to receipt and does not make it an approval.

11

Background reading: [Digital.gov: writing for understanding](#). The conversation is an original fictional teaching case.

Find the move you need

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

01 Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Acknowledge the confusion: I can see why these two documents are easy to confuse.

State the current condition: The current residence requirement is twelve months.

Keep the decision boundary: This explanation is not a formal eligibility determination.

Full phrase set: pages 7-8 | Dialogue: pages 10-11

02 Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

Acknowledge the contribution: Thank you; your concern has been recorded.

Move the queue: I will now call the next person awaiting an initial turn.

Offer the stated route: Written submissions remain open until Friday at 17:00 local time.

Full phrase set: pages 16-17 | Dialogue: pages 19-20

03 Procurement and Vendor Selection

Ask for the rationale: What does best value mean under this selection method?

Avoid double weighting: These scores have already been weighted.

Explain the trade-off: The note must explain why the assessed benefit justifies the premium.

Full phrase set: pages 25-26 | Dialogue: pages 28-29

04 Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

Identify the award: We are reconciling the quarterly report for G62.

Locate the difference: The one-thousand-dollar gap is in personnel.

Preserve the classification: Do not move the amount into travel just to balance the report.

Full phrase set: pages 34-35 | Dialogue: pages 37-38

Keep the conversation productive

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

05 Interagency Coordination

Name the gap: Each office assumed the other would contact the resident.

Set the internal time: Transit will send its status to Jon by 14:30.

Use the reference: Please quote Q41 in both records.

Full phrase set: pages 43-44 | Dialogue: pages 46-47

06 Constituent Services and Escalation

Acknowledge the history: You have already been redirected repeatedly.

Explain the receiving office: Public Works Permit Intake receives the sidewalk-use application.

Offer continuity: With the appropriate authorization, I will pass on the relevant case summary.

Full phrase set: pages 52-53 | Dialogue: pages 55-56

07 Transparency, Records, and Ethics

State the search result: We located eight responsive contract files.

Correct the earlier promise: The acknowledgment should not have promised automatic full disclosure.

Check partial disclosure: Which information can be separated and released?

Full phrase set: pages 61-62 | Dialogue: pages 64-65

08 Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

State the funding request: We are requesting two hundred forty thousand dollars for next year.

Name the output: We delivered twenty workshops.

State the current denominator: The current rate is 105 out of 210 respondents.

Full phrase set: pages 70-71 | Dialogue: pages 73-74

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

acceptance of responsibility	record acceptance of responsibility	41
accessibility arrangement	coordinate accessibility arrangements	15
accommodation request	handle an accommodation request	15
acknowledgment	issue an acknowledgment	59
acknowledgment of receipt	request acknowledgment of receipt	41
action owner	assign an action owner	41
activity	describe program activities	68
actual expenditure	report actual expenditure	68
administrative appeal	explain the administrative appeal route	60
adoption	confirm adoption	5
agenda	follow the agenda	14
allocable cost	assess cost allocability	33
allowable cost	assess cost allowability	33
application intake	arrange application intake	5
application receipt	confirm application receipt	51
appropriation	distinguish a request from an appropriation	68
attachment	review the attachments	59
attendance	count attendances	68
attribution	check attribution	15
attribution	support causal attribution	69
audit trail	preserve the audit trail	24
availability check	complete an availability check	41
award authority	confirm award authority	24
award terms	review the award terms	32

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

best value explain the best-value judgment	23
booking confirmation issue booking confirmation	41
budget category reconcile budget categories	32
budget justification strengthen the budget justification	68
budget request submit a budget request	68
business registration verify business registration	50
case continuity maintain case continuity	51
case summary prepare a case summary	50
case-specific advice seek case-specific advice	6
certification review the certification	33
clarification request clarification	15
closed-loop handoff complete a closed-loop handoff	42
closeout prepare for closeout	33
closure reason record the closure reason	51
cohort compare cohorts	68
comment deadline verify the comment deadline	6
complaint reference provide the complaint reference	51
completeness check perform a completeness check	5
completeness review conduct a completeness review	51
conflict of interest disclose a conflict of interest	24
constituent service provide constituent service	50
consultation conduct a consultation	14
corrected report submit a corrected report	33
cost share document cost share	33

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

counterfactual define the counterfactual	69
current guidance consult current guidance	5
data-sharing authority verify data-sharing authority	42
date range confirm the date range	59
debriefing prepare a debriefing	24
decision authority identify the decision authority	15
decision deadline verify the decision deadline	51
deficiency identify a deficiency	24
deliberation distinguish input from deliberation	15
denominator state the denominator	69
dependency tracker maintain the dependency tracker	42
disclosure review conduct disclosure review	59
discretion exercise defined discretion	6
draft guidance identify draft guidance	5
effective date check the effective date	5
eligibility criterion verify an eligibility criterion	5
eligibility determination issue an eligibility determination	6
eligibility review complete the eligibility review	42
escalation contact identify the escalation contact	42
evaluation factor apply the evaluation factors	23
evaluation narrative complete the evaluation narrative	24
exception check an authorized exception	6
exemption assess an exemption	59
expenditure report expenditures	32

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

facilitator support the facilitator	14
FOIA process a FOIA request	59
follow-up call schedule a follow-up call	51
follow-up survey conduct a follow-up survey	69
foreseeable harm assess foreseeable harm	60
general ledger reconcile the general ledger	32
grant award identify the grant award	32
handoff confirm the handoff	41
impact assess program impact	68
implementation date confirm the implementation date	5
indirect cost review indirect costs	33
initial turn complete initial turns	14
input identify program inputs	68
intake office identify the intake office	50
interagency coordinate interagency work	41
interpretation arrange interpretation	15
joint status prepare a joint status	42
jurisdiction clarify jurisdiction	50
lead contact appoint a lead contact	41
measurement plan develop the measurement plan	69
meeting clerk brief the meeting clerk	14
meeting record maintain the meeting record	15
minimum necessary data share the minimum necessary data	42
nonresponse bias assess nonresponse bias	69

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

notice read the notice	6
obligation distinguish obligations from expenditures	33
offeror evaluate the offeror	23
oral submission record an oral submission	15
outcome measure outcomes	68
output measure outputs	68
partial release prepare a partial release	60
pass-through entity contact the pass-through entity	32
past performance assess past performance	24
percentage point report percentage-point change	69
performance target set a performance target	69
permit condition explain permit conditions	51
personal privacy assess personal-privacy interests	60
personnel cost document personnel costs	32
pickup zone confirm the pickup zone	42
price premium justify the price premium	23
procedural reminder give a procedural reminder	14
procurement manage procurement	23
program rule explain the program rules	5
proposal distinguish the proposal	5
public comment submit public comment	6
public liaison contact the public liaison	60
purpose limitation observe purpose limitation	42
receiving office confirm the receiving office	41

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

recipient identify the recipient	32
reconciliation complete the reconciliation	33
records custodian contact the records custodian	59
records preservation maintain records preservation	60
records request clarify a records request	59
recusal arrange recusal	24
redaction apply justified redactions	60
referral make a referral	50
referral acceptance verify referral acceptance	50
referring office identify the referring office	41
relative change distinguish relative change	69
relative importance state relative importance	23
release copy verify the release copy	60
reporting period confirm the reporting period	32
request reference quote the request reference	42
request scope confirm the request scope	59
requested window record the requested window	42
residence requirement explain the residence requirement	5
respondent identify respondents	69
response rate calculate the response rate	69
response target state the response target	51
responsibility matrix update the responsibility matrix	41
responsive record identify responsive records	59
retention schedule follow the retention schedule	60

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

review route	explain the review route	51
review status	explain the review status	60
rulemaking	follow the rulemaking process	6
scoring matrix	reconcile the scoring matrix	23
search terms	document the search terms	59
second turn	allow second turns	14
secure channel	use the secure channel	42
segregable information	identify segregable information	60
selection effect	examine selection effects	69
service complaint	record a service complaint	51
service dependency	identify service dependencies	41
service history	review the service history	50
service remit	explain the service remit	50
service-delivery plan	assess the service-delivery plan	23
sidewalk-use permit	apply for a sidewalk-use permit	50
site plan	submit a site plan	50
solicitation	review the solicitation	23
source documentation	obtain source documentation	32
source selection	support source selection	24
speaker queue	manage the speaker queue	14
speaking allocation	explain the speaking allocation	14
stakeholder	hear from stakeholders	14
statutory authority	identify statutory authority	6
strength	substantiate a strength	24

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

subfactor assess the subfactor	23
submission deadline state the submission deadline	15
subrecipient monitor the subrecipient	32
substantive review await substantive review	51
summary verify the summary	15
superseded version identify a superseded version	6
supporting evidence identify supporting evidence	6
supporting schedule prepare a supporting schedule	32
technical approach evaluate the technical approach	23
time limit apply the time limit	14
tracking number quote the tracking number	59
trade-off document the trade-off	24
transition provision check transition provisions	5
unique participant count unique participants	68
unobligated balance report the unobligated balance	33
unsupported item flag an unsupported item	33
variance explain the variance	33
verification complete verification	6
viewpoint neutrality maintain viewpoint neutrality	14
warm referral arrange a warm referral	50
weakness document a weakness	24
weighted score verify the weighted scores	23
withholding basis document the withholding basis	60
written submission accept written submissions	15

Original cases. Clear boundaries.

These are original fictional teaching conversations, not transcripts of real workers. Names, figures, organizations, and incidents are invented. Sources support terminology and communication aims, not the fictional results or an endorsement of this book.

[1] Office of the Federal Register. A Guide to the Rulemaking Process.

[Open the original source](#)

Background on proposals, public comments, and final rules. Fictional program conditions are not actual eligibility rules or a universal account of rulemaking. Checked 1 October 2026.

[2] Federal Acquisition Regulation 15.304. Evaluation factors and significant subfactors.

[Open the original source](#)

Background on disclosed evaluation factors and their importance in U.S. federal negotiated procurement. The invented scoring example is not a universal selection method. Checked 1 October 2026.

[3] Electronic Code of Federal Regulations. 2 CFR 200.302: Financial management.

[Open the original source](#)

Background on federal-award financial records and source documentation. The fictional reporting categories and figures illustrate reconciliation language, not cost allowability decisions. Checked 1 October 2026.

[4] FOIA.gov. Frequently Asked Questions.

[Open the original source](#)

Background on U.S. federal records requests, review, exemptions, and partial disclosure. The records dialogue does not determine an exemption or prescribe local-law procedures. Checked 1 October 2026.

Phil Stilwell

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